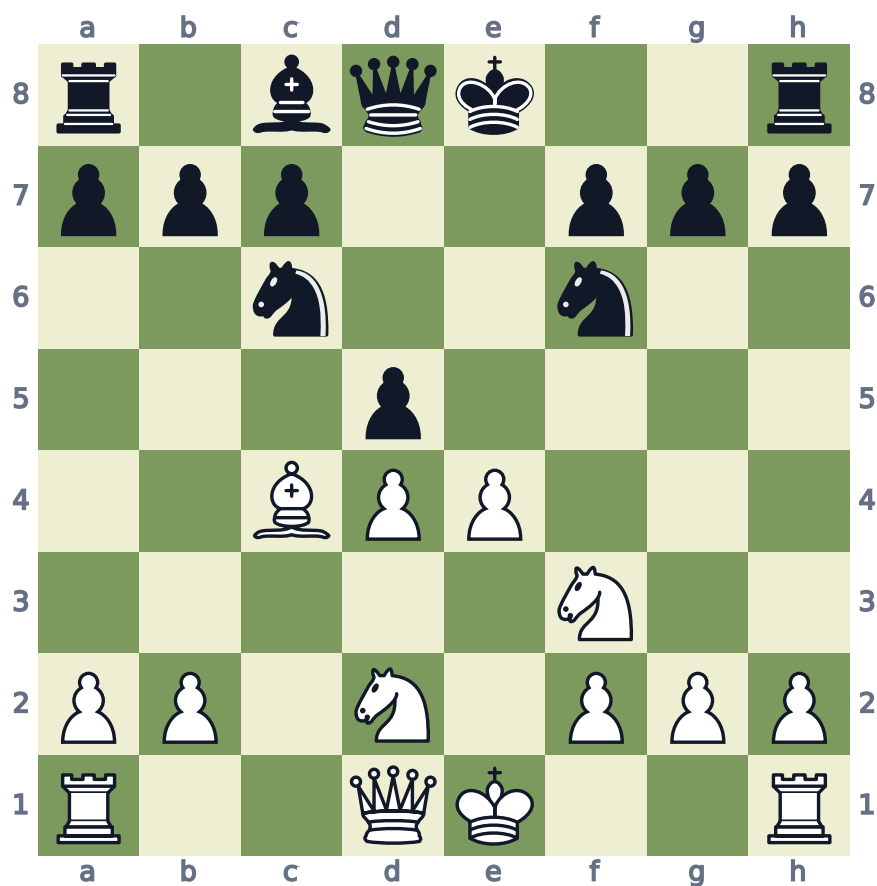


Positional Evaluation Tests

Material, kings, activity, structure, space, and plans



Turn vague impressions into an explicit verdict and plan, then compare your reasoning with an engine-checked line and a human-readable position map.

30 practice units | separated solutions | scoring | review plan

ORIENTATION

How to get real improvement from this course

PURPOSE

Turn vague impressions into an explicit verdict and plan, then compare your reasoning with an engine-checked line and a human-readable position map.

TRAINING RULES

- Evaluate before calculating so the endpoint has a comparison standard.
- Do not add factors mechanically; king danger and forcing initiative can dominate everything else.
- A weakness matters only when the opponent can reach it.
- Finish with a plan and the opponent's best counterplan, not a static label.
-

COURSE SIZE

This PDF contains 30 practice units. Problems appear before their solutions whenever practical. Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days.

SCORING

What a complete answer contains

RECOGNITION

Name the tactical or strategic feature without assuming that the familiar pattern works.

CANDIDATES

List serious forcing and improving choices before analyzing deeply.

BEST RESISTANCE

Calculate the opponent's least cooperative legal response.

ENDPOINT

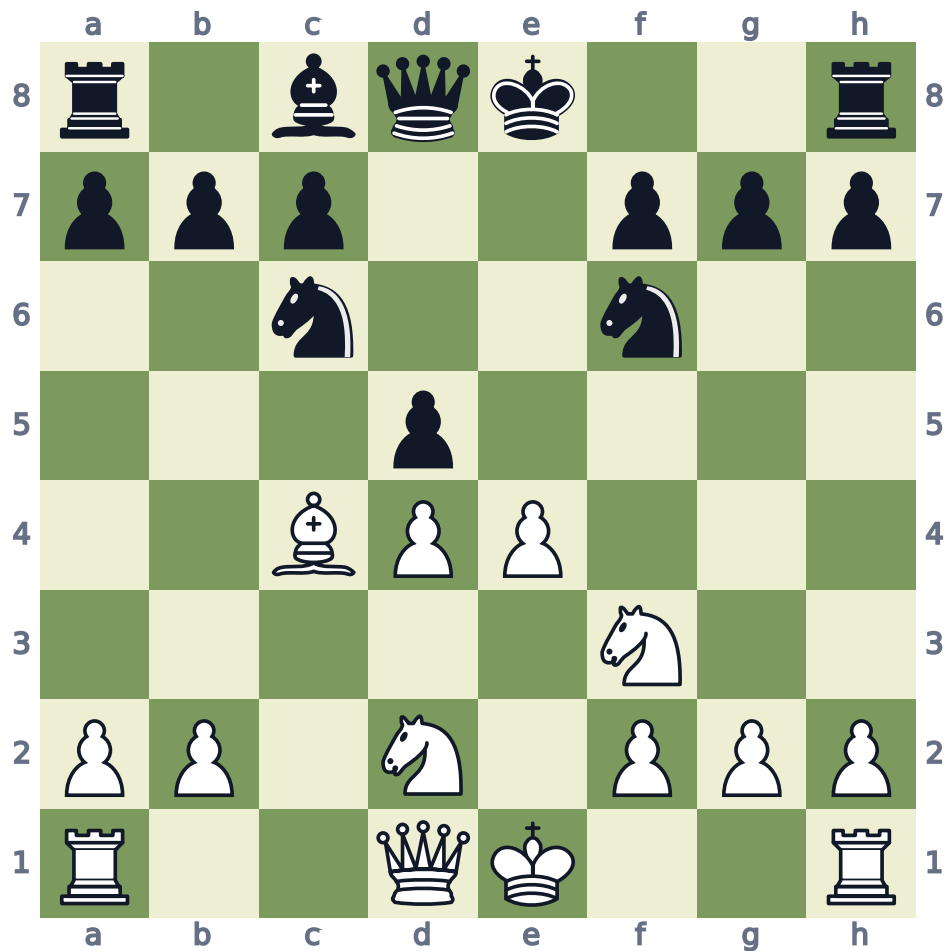
Stop only after forcing play settles, then evaluate material, kings, activity, and structure.

TRANSFER

State the visible cue that should make you remember this position during a game.

PROBLEM 01 OF 30

Italian Game



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

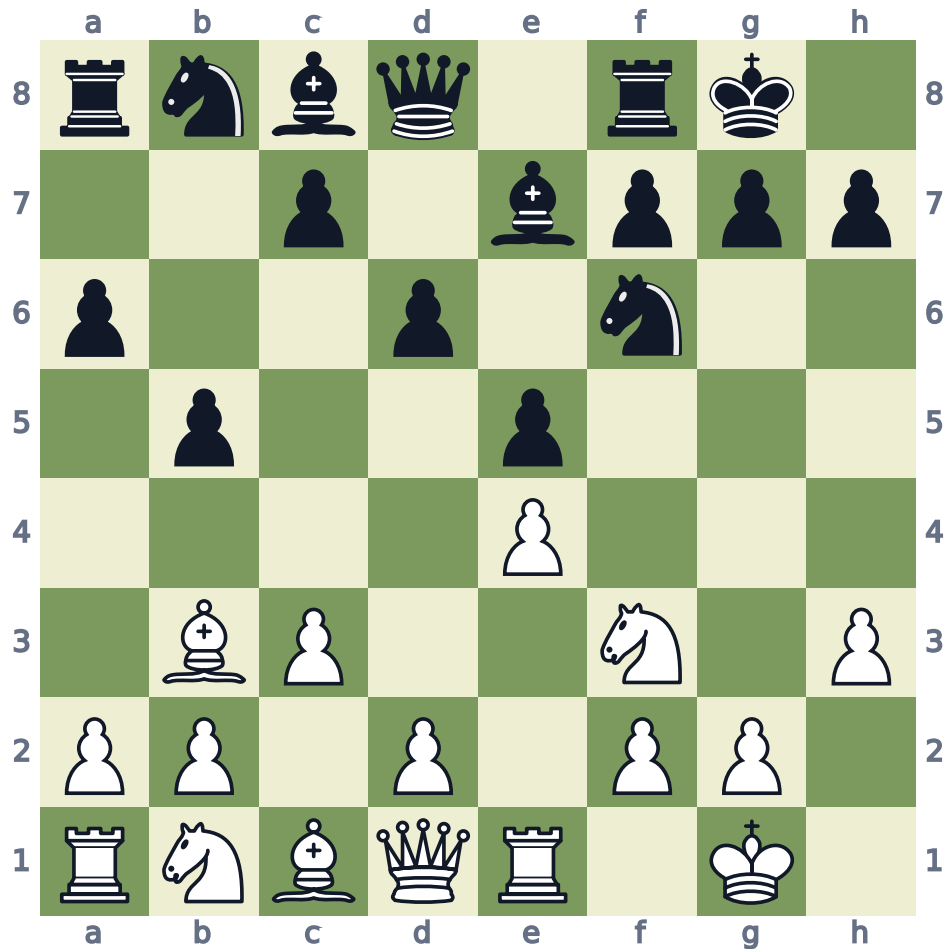
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 02 OF 30

Ruy Lopez



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

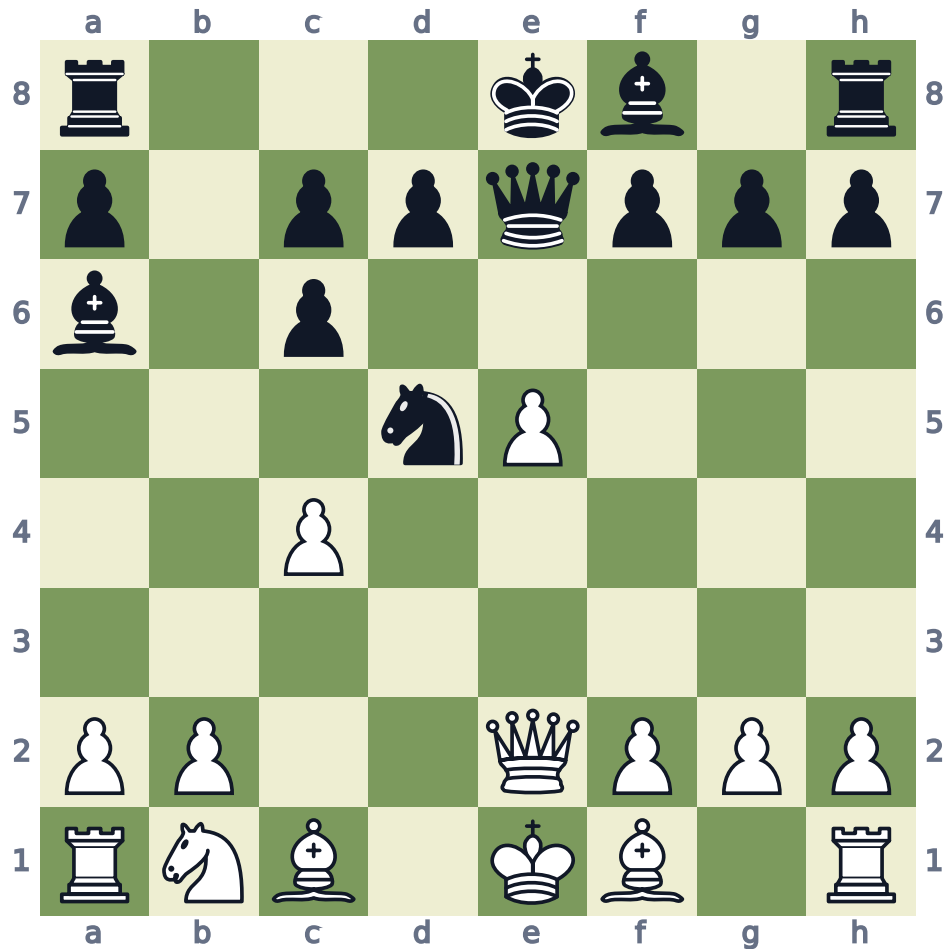
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 03 OF 30

Scotch Game



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

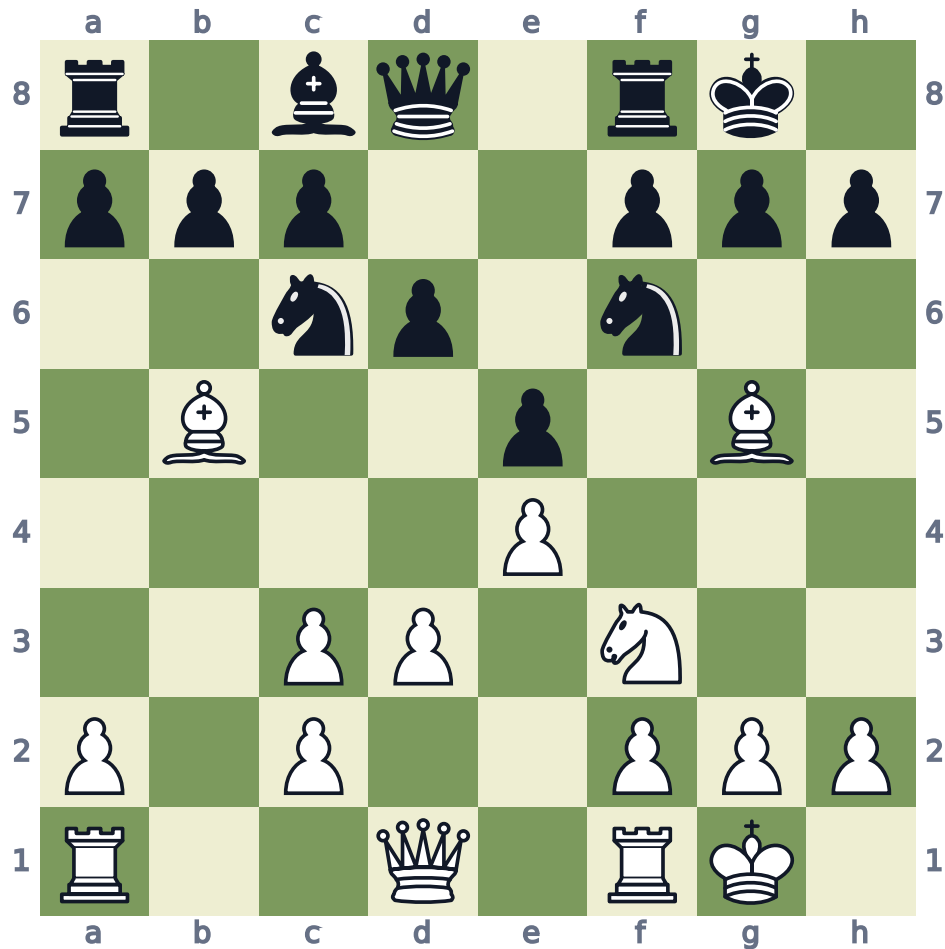
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 04 OF 30

Four Knights Game



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

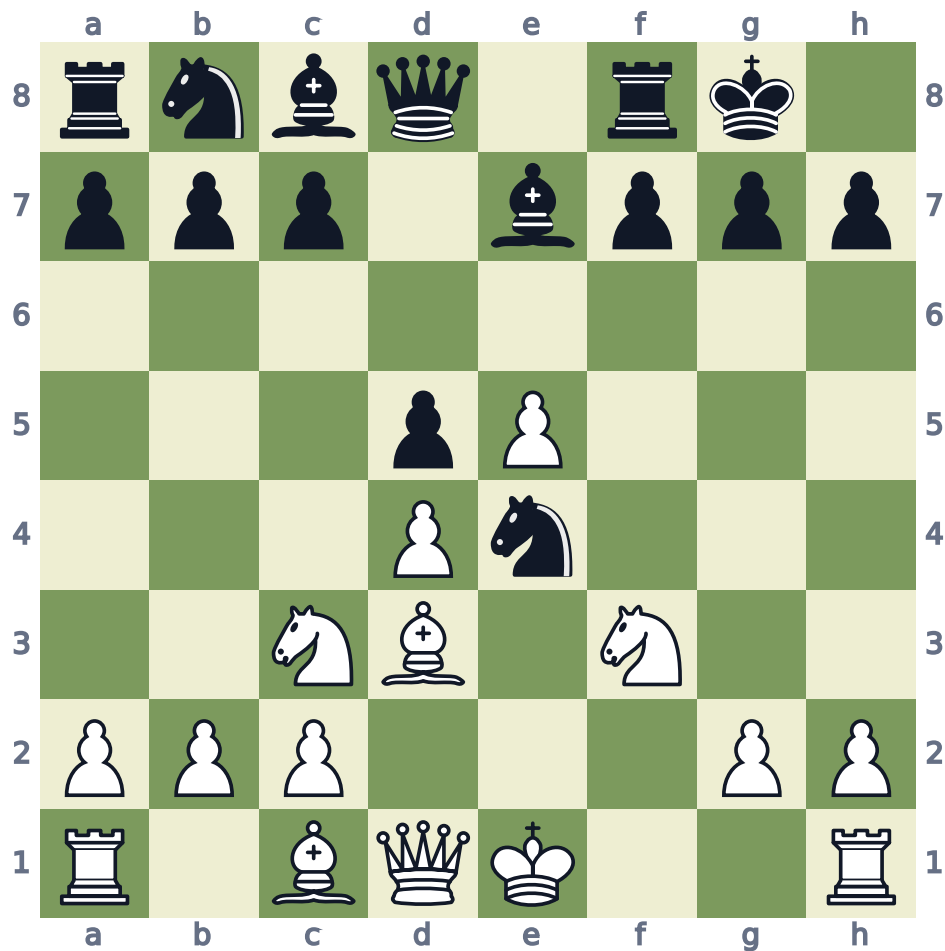
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 05 OF 30

Vienna Game

**YOUR TASK**

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

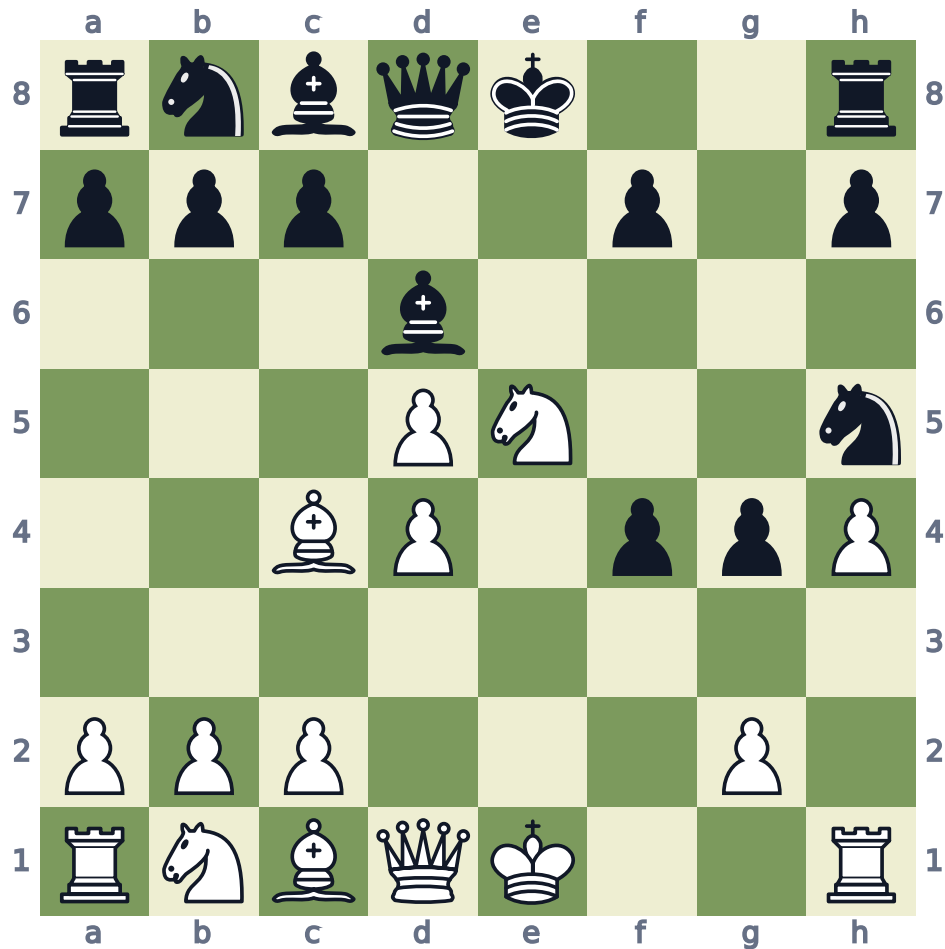
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 06 OF 30

King's Gambit

**YOUR TASK**

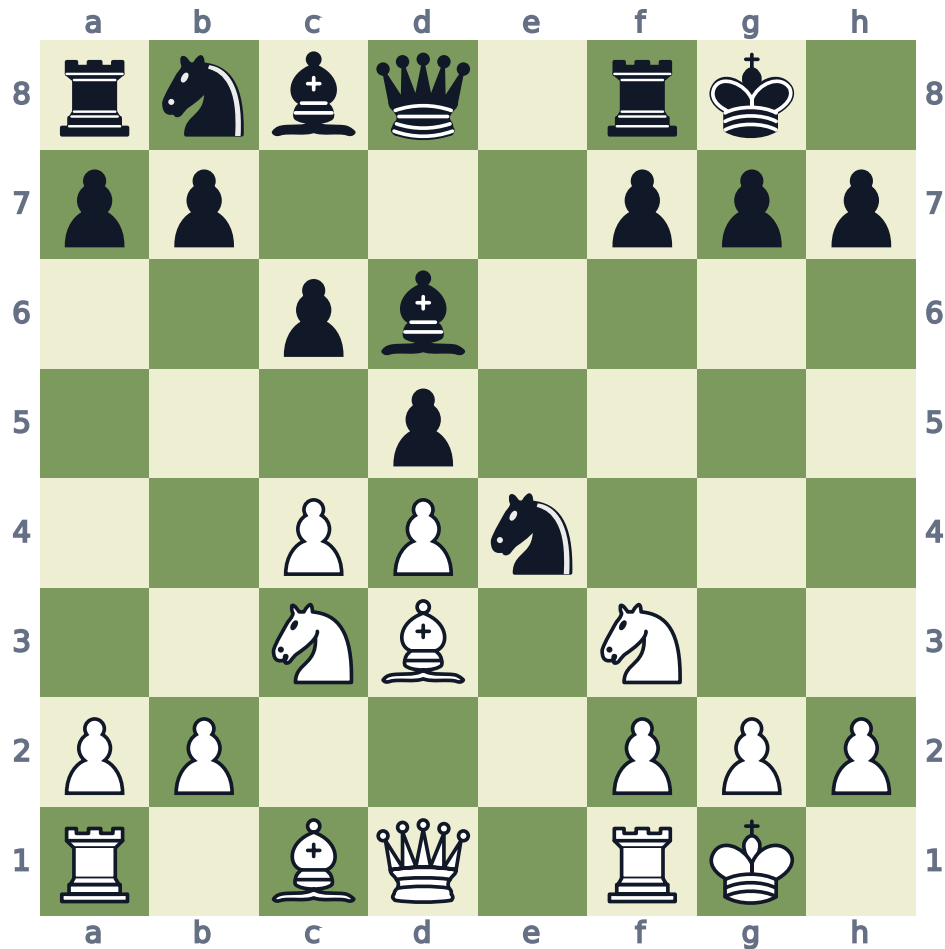
Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY**Full positional evaluation****BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION**

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 07 OF 30

Petrov Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

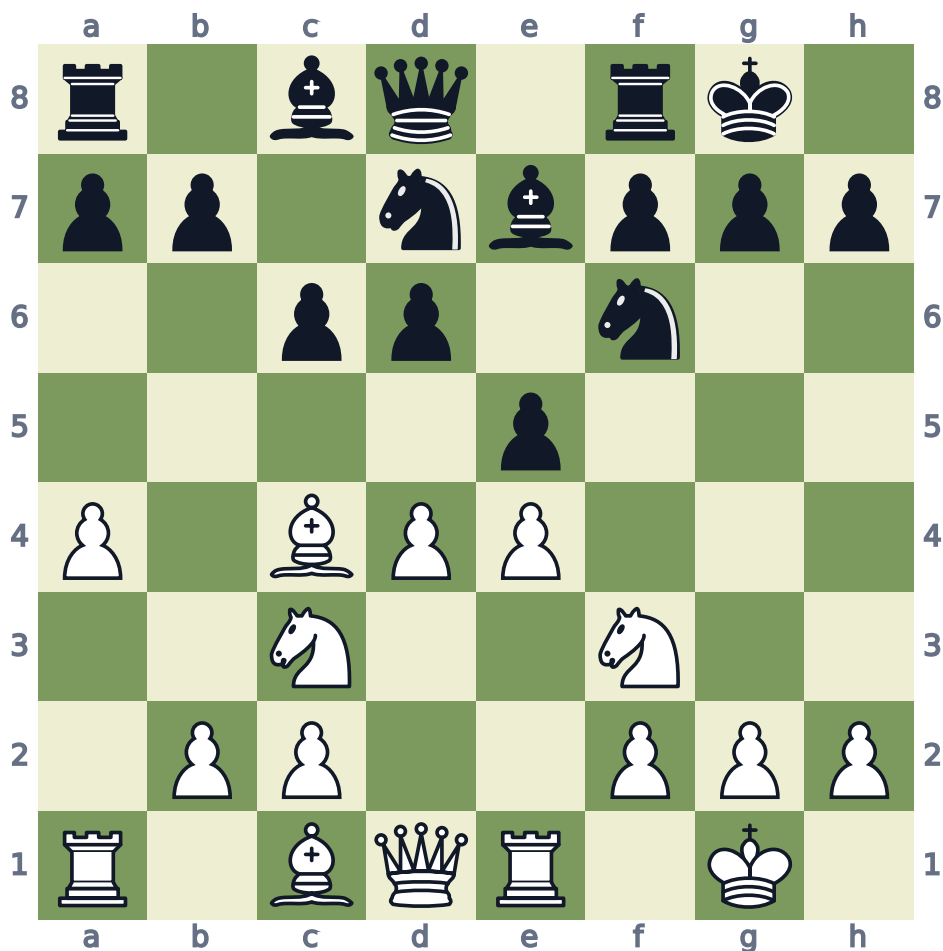
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 08 OF 30

Philidor Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

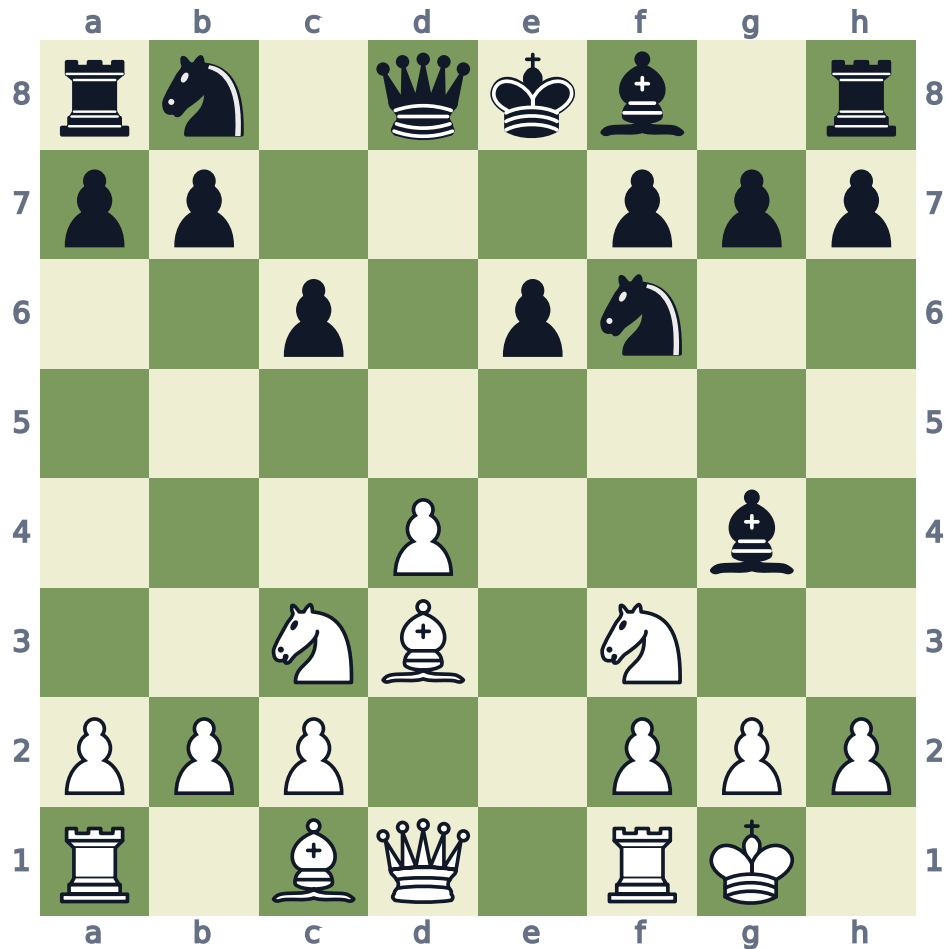
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 09 OF 30

Scandinavian Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 10 OF 30

French Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

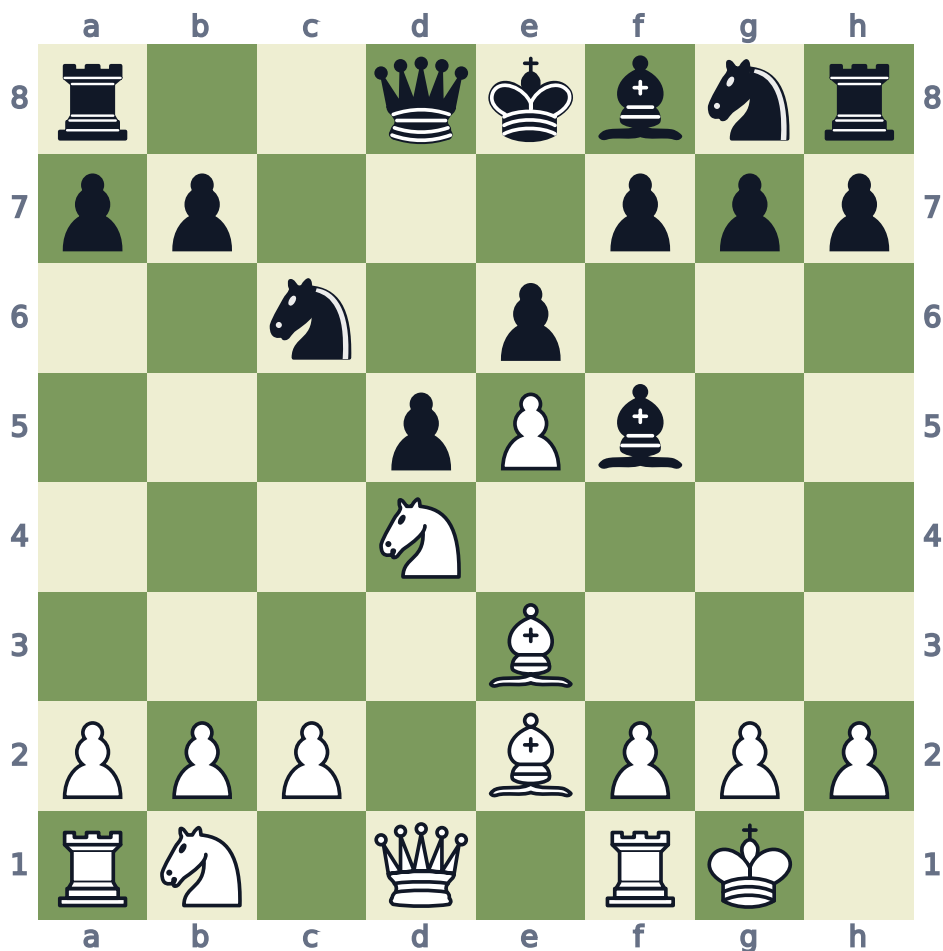
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 11 OF 30

Caro-Kann Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

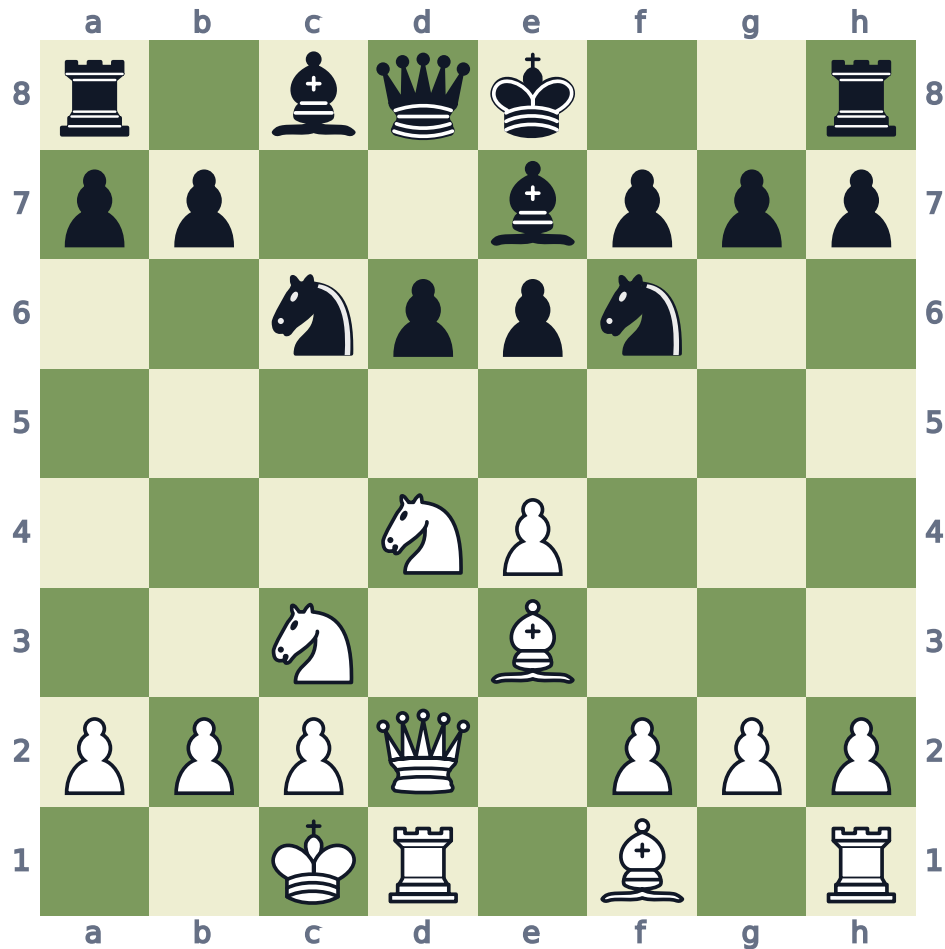
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 12 OF 30

Open Sicilian



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

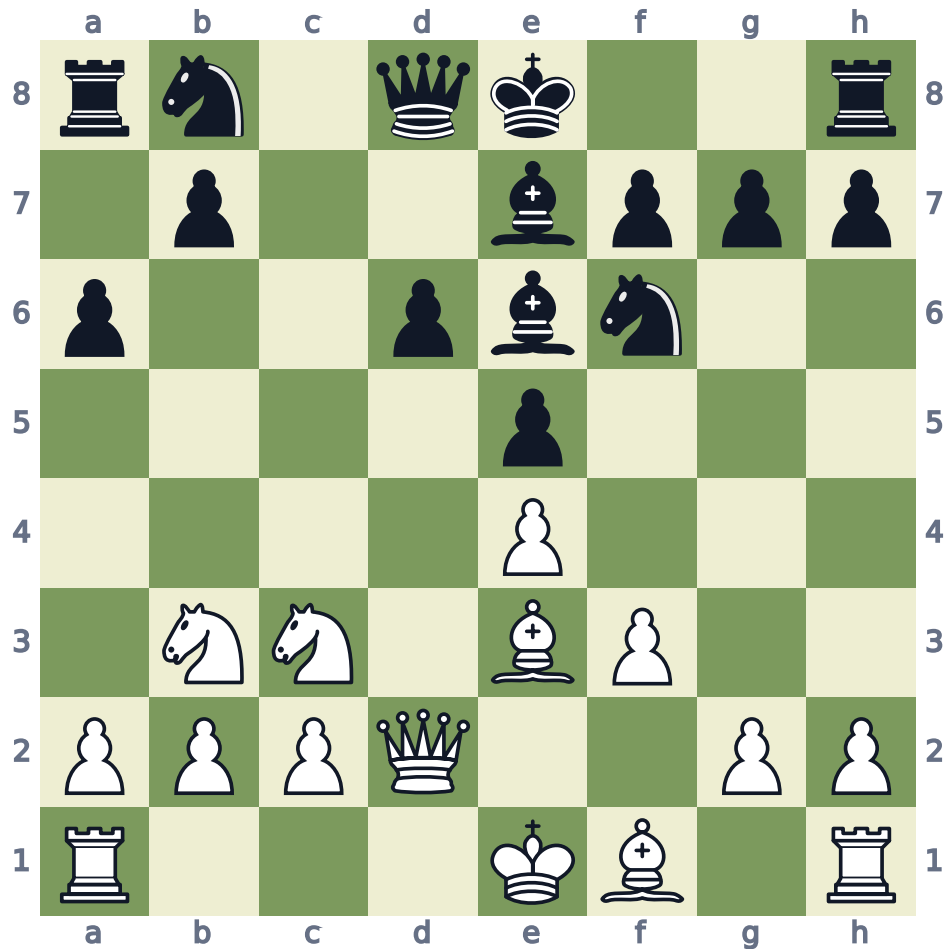
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 13 OF 30

Sicilian Najdorf



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

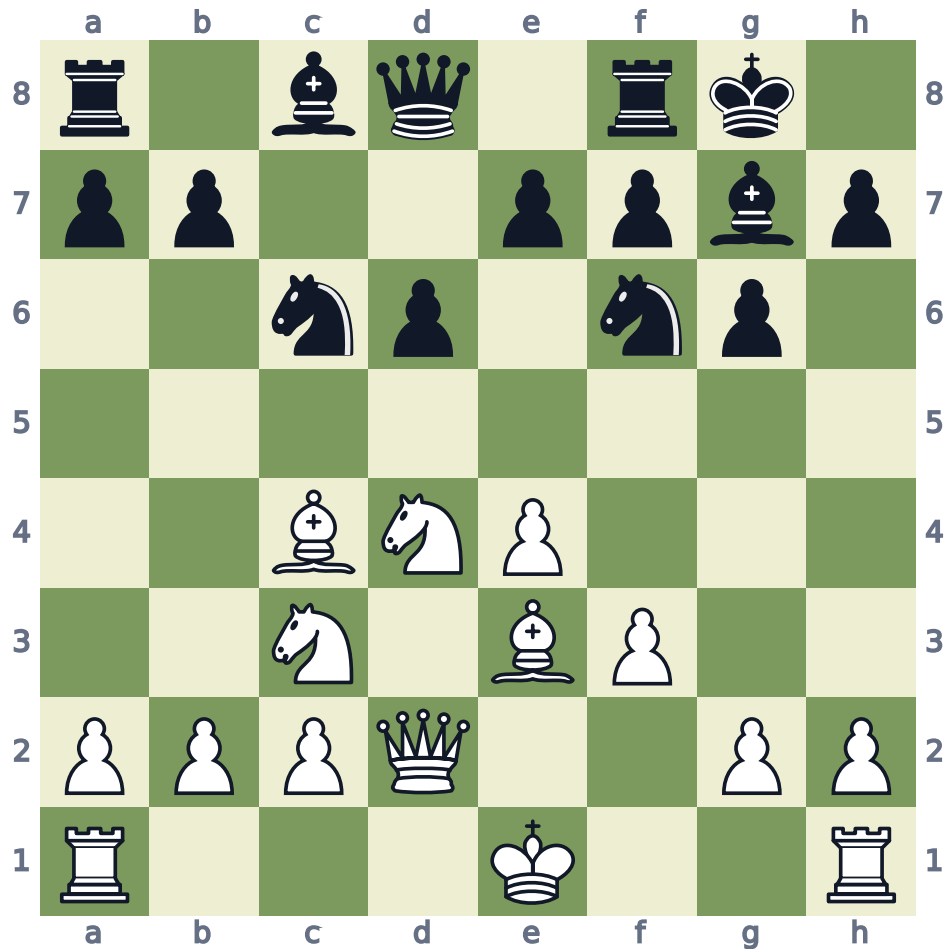
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 14 OF 30

Sicilian Dragon



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

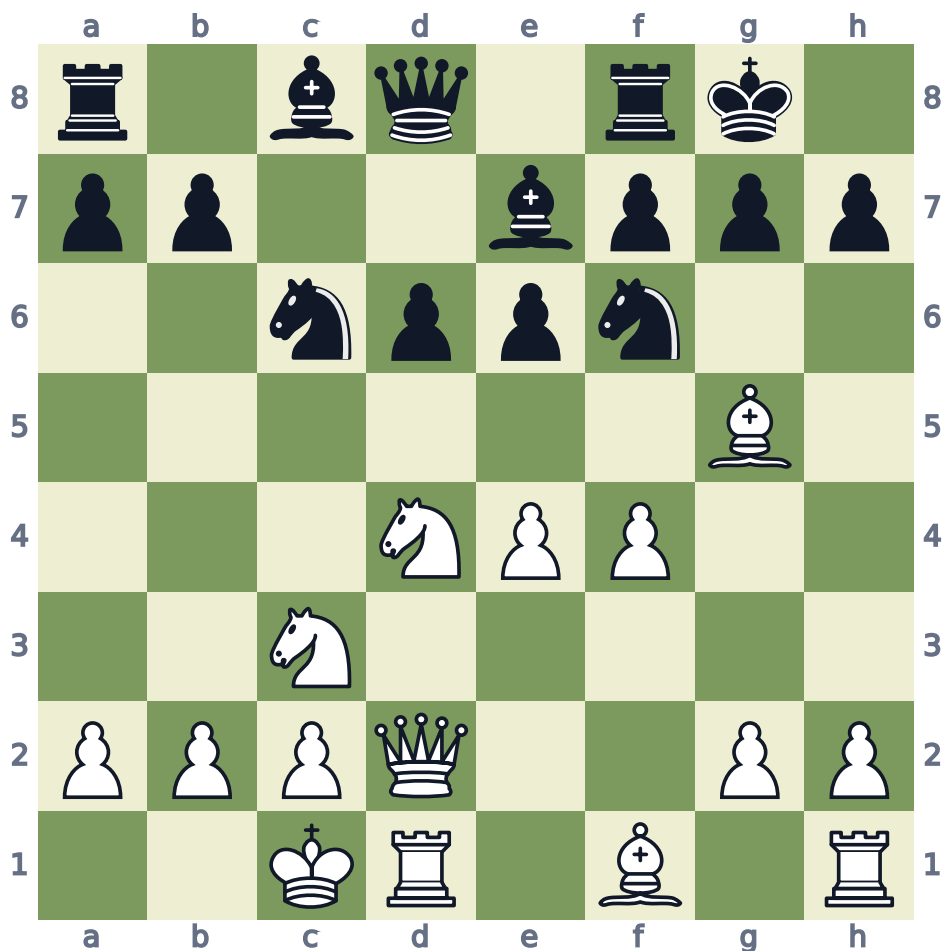
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 15 OF 30

Classical Sicilian



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

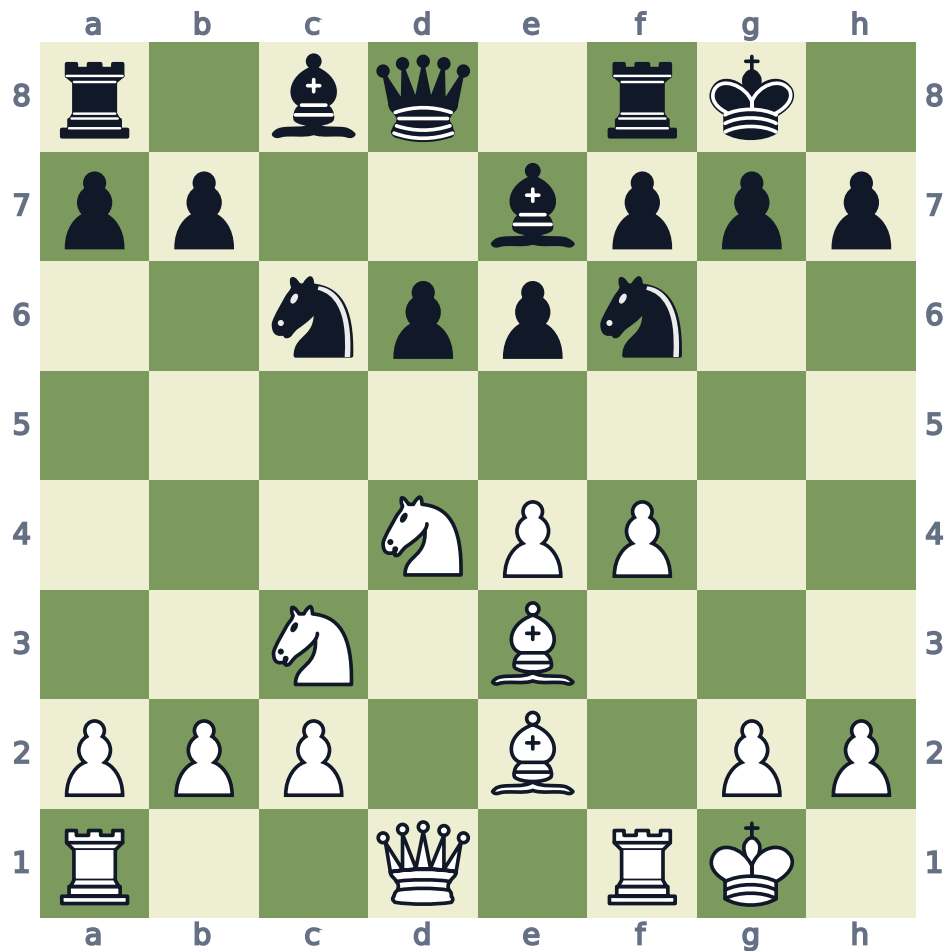
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 16 OF 30

Sicilian Scheveningen



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

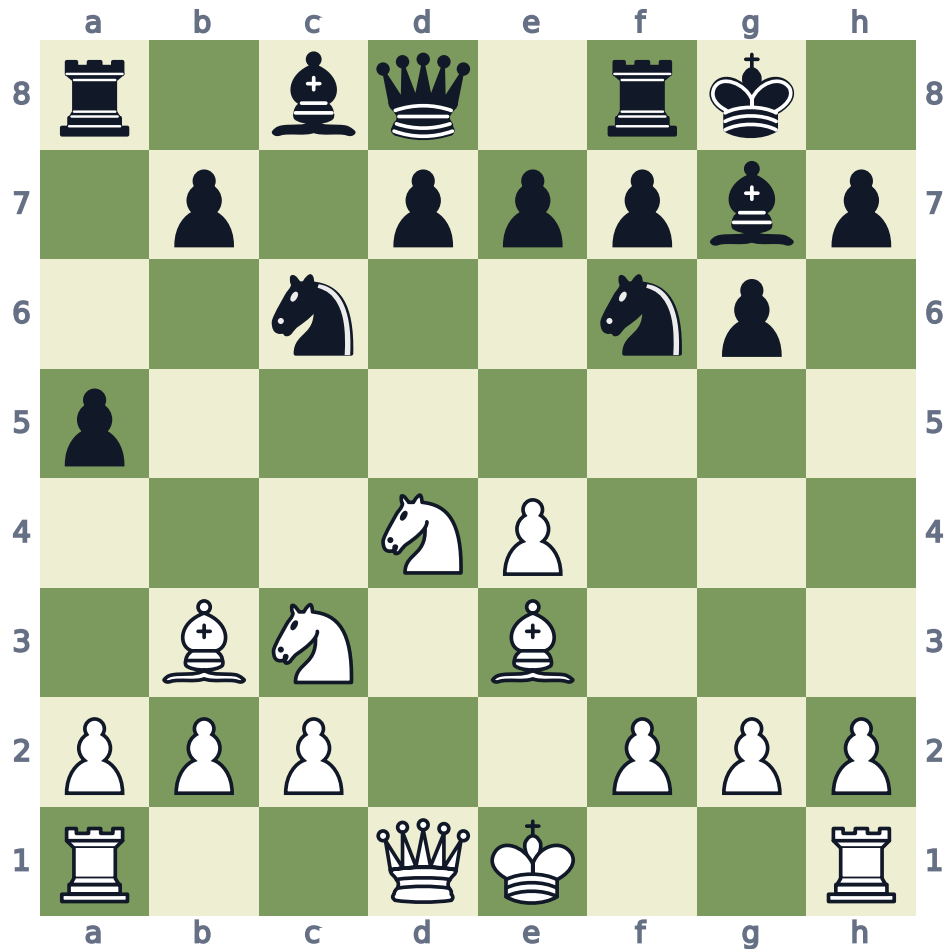
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 17 OF 30

Accelerated Dragon



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

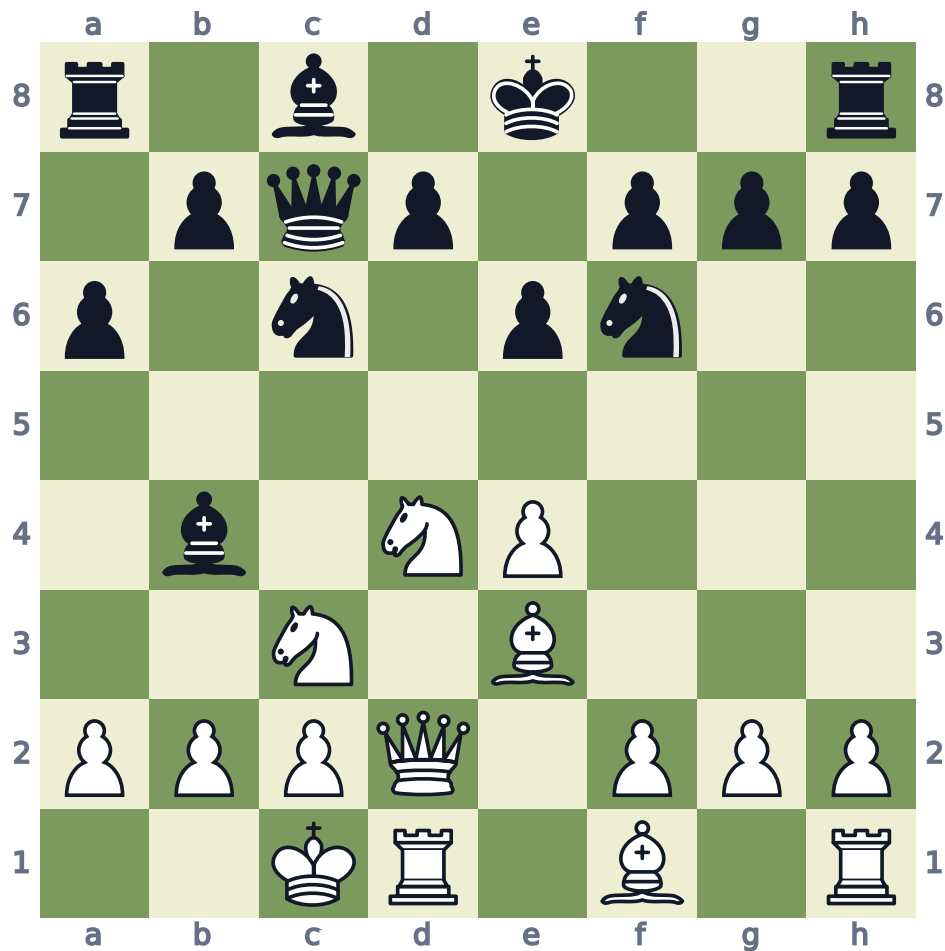
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 18 OF 30

Sicilian Taimanov



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

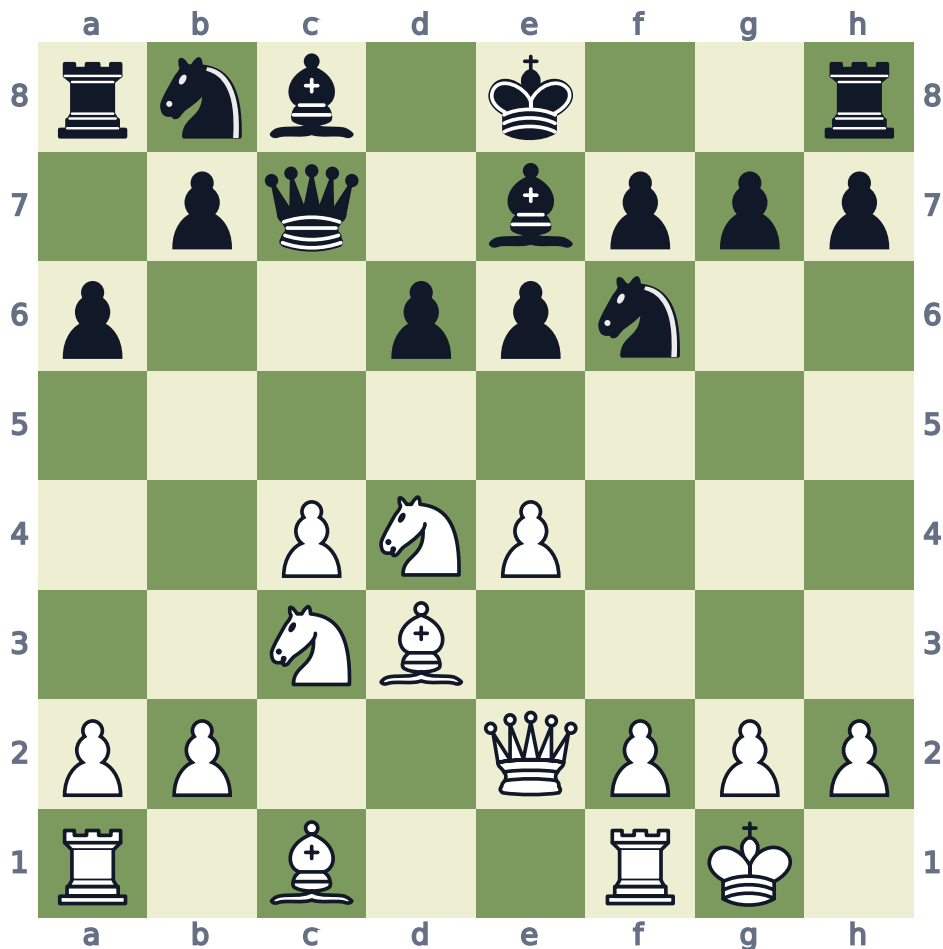
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 19 OF 30

Sicilian Kan



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

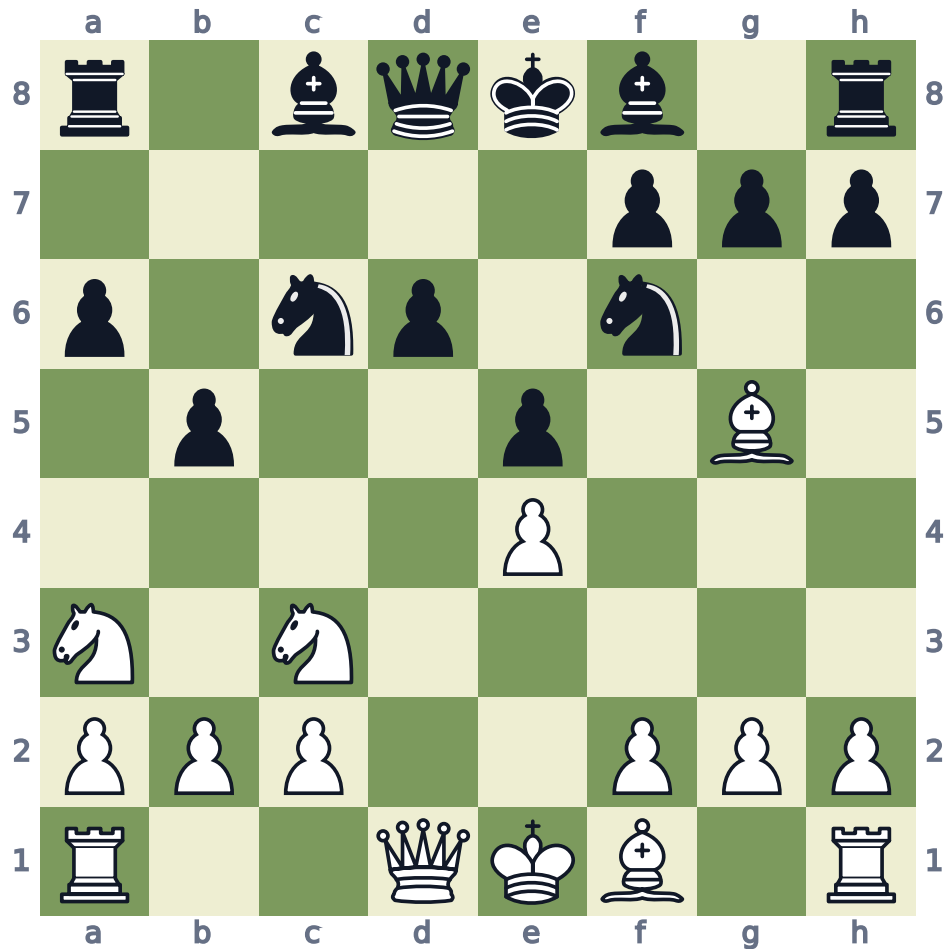
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 20 OF 30

Sicilian Sveshnikov



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

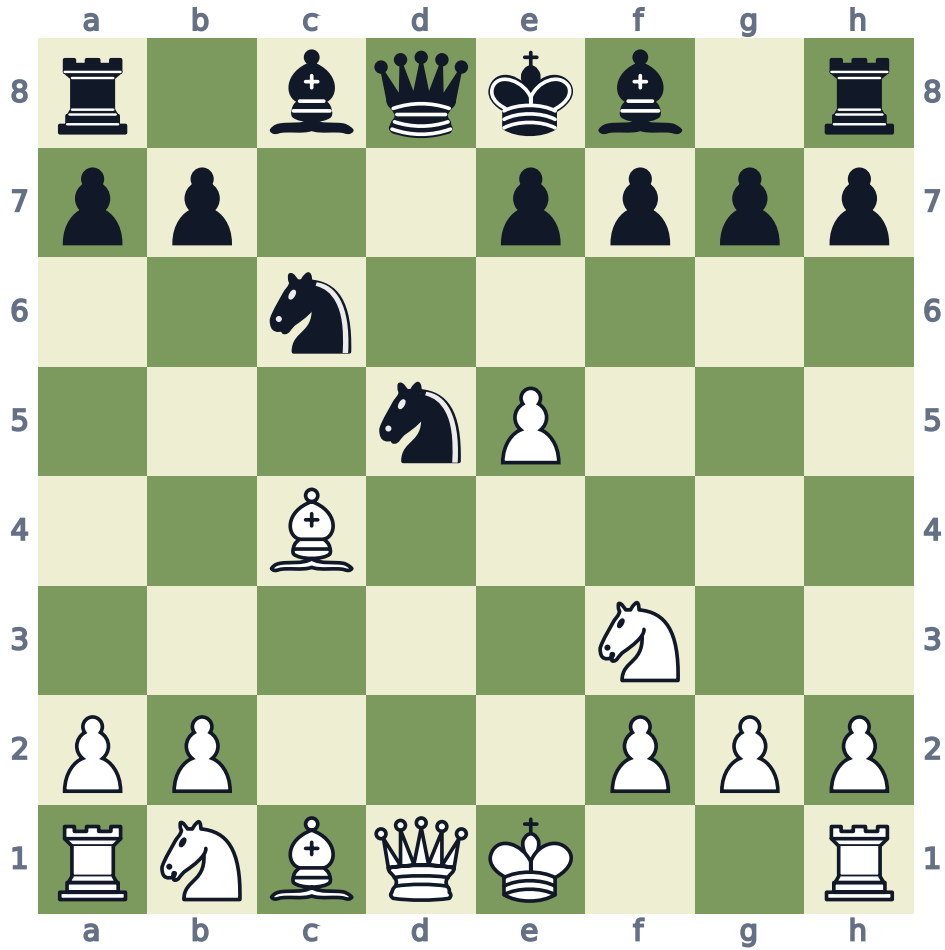
DIFFICULTY

Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

Sicilian Alapin



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

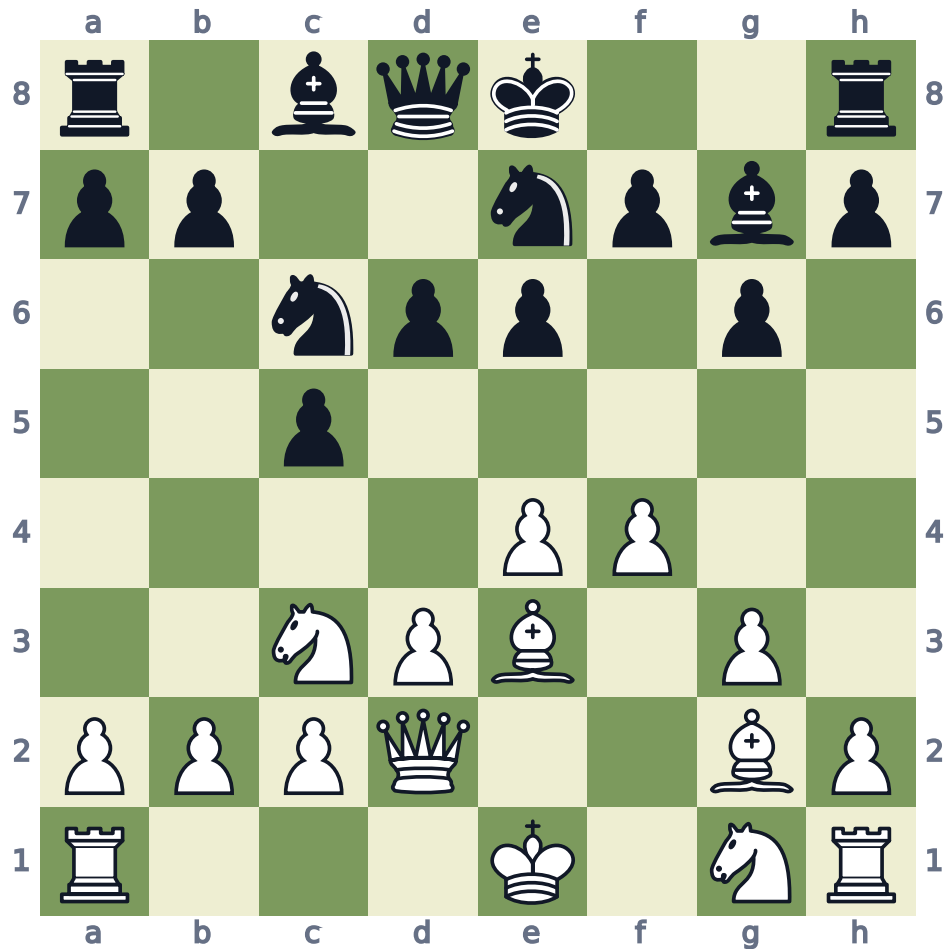
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 22 OF 30

Closed Sicilian



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

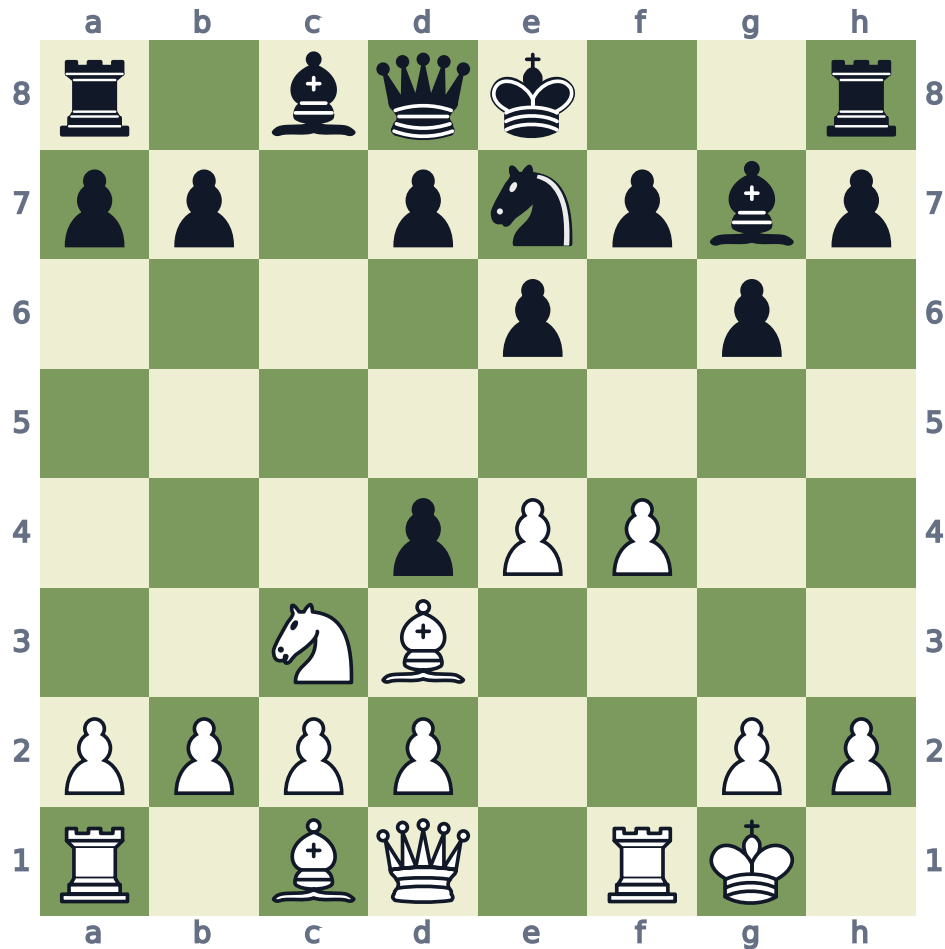
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 23 OF 30

Grand Prix Attack



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

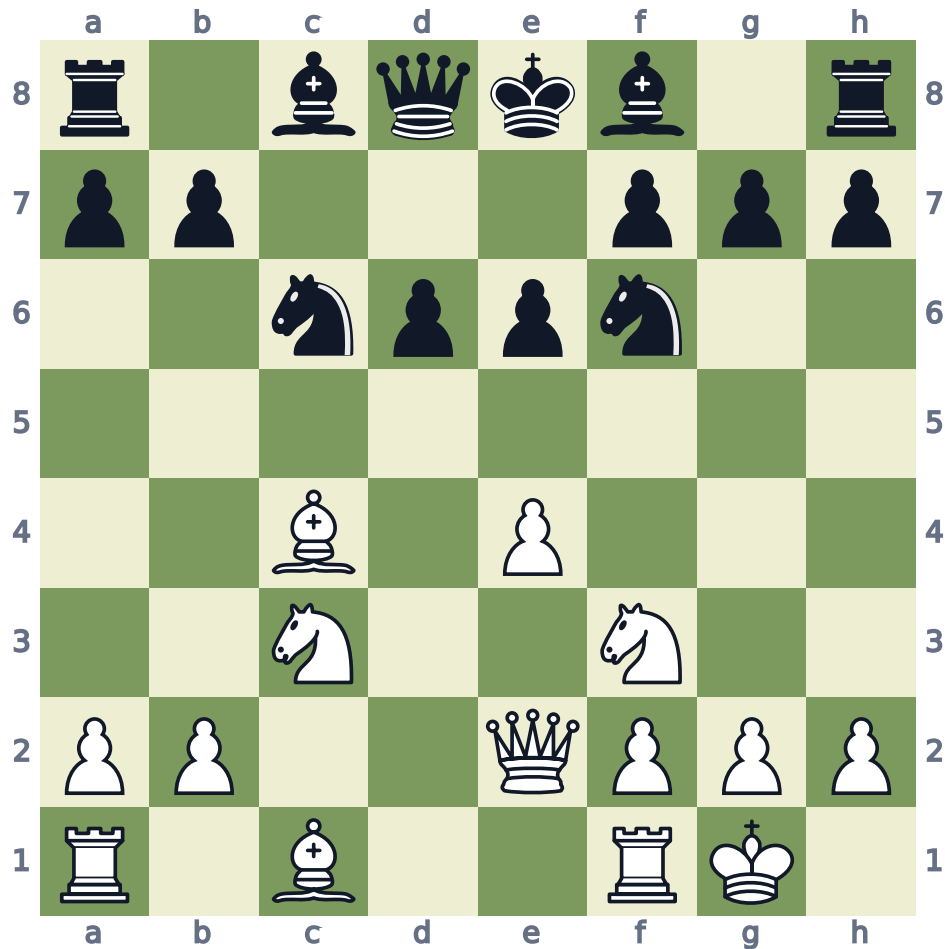
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 24 OF 30

Smith-Morra Gambit



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

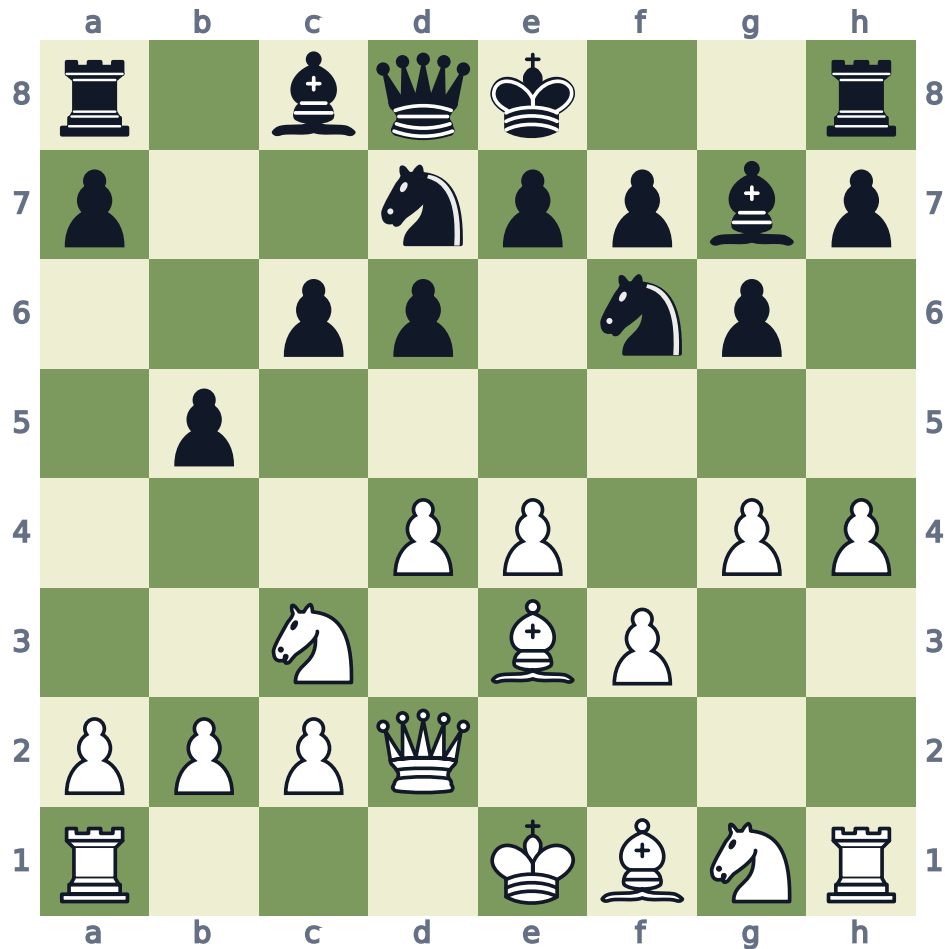
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 25 OF 30

Pirc Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

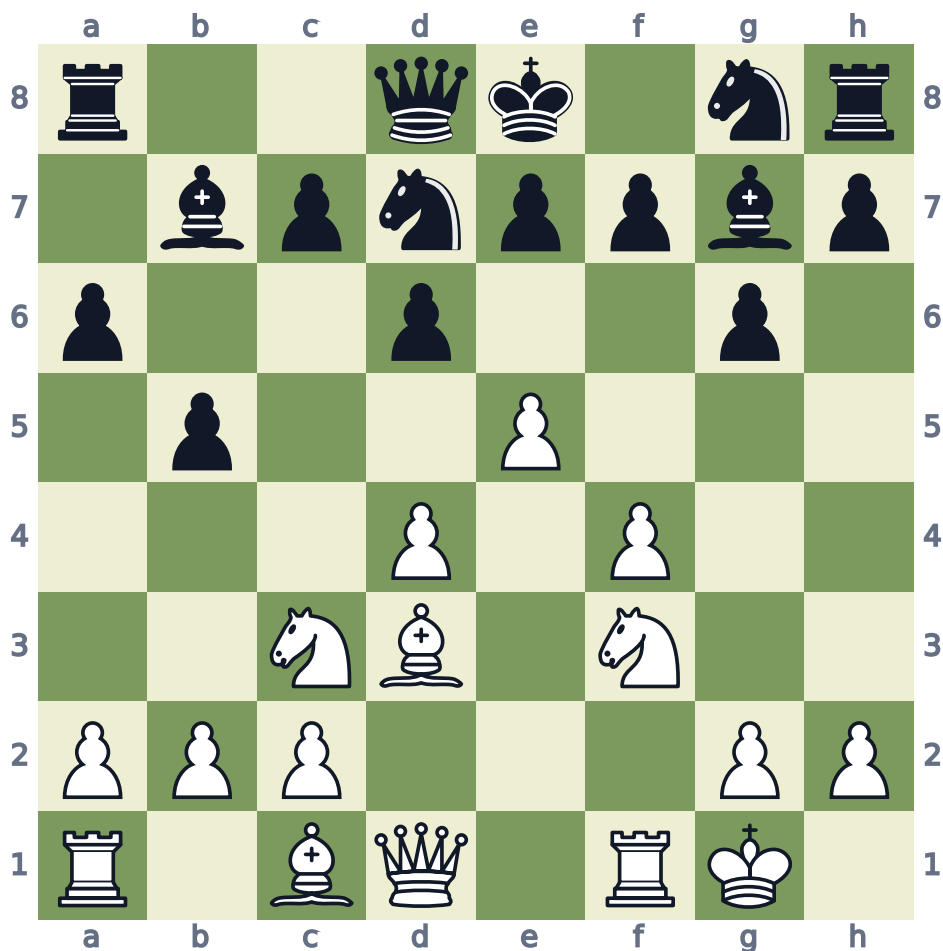
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 26 OF 30

Modern Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

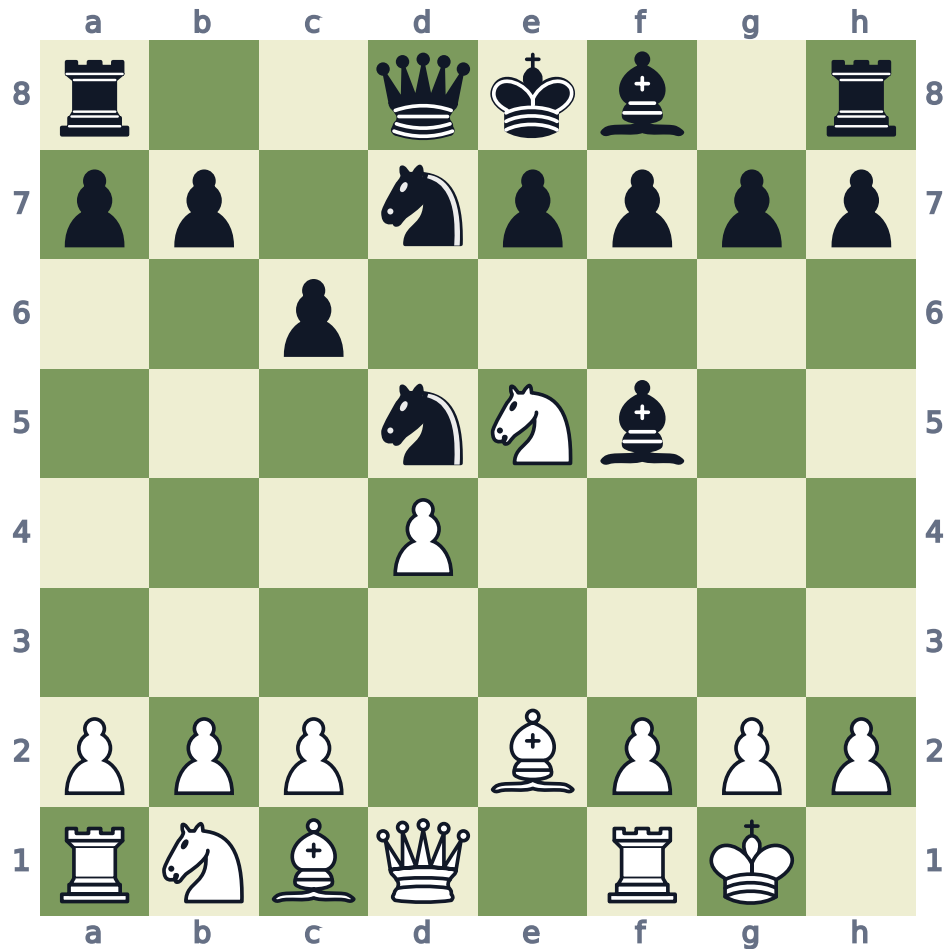
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 27 OF 30

Alekhine Defense

**YOUR TASK**

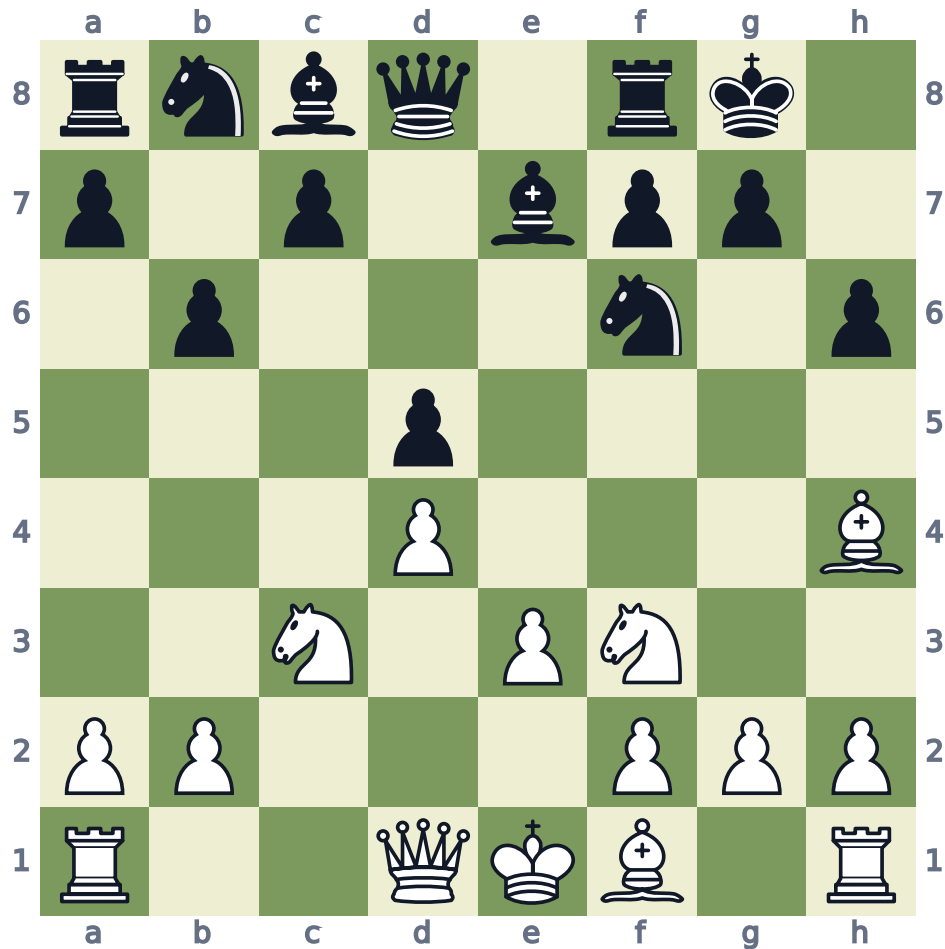
Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY**Full positional evaluation****BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION**

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 28 OF 30

Queen's Gambit



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

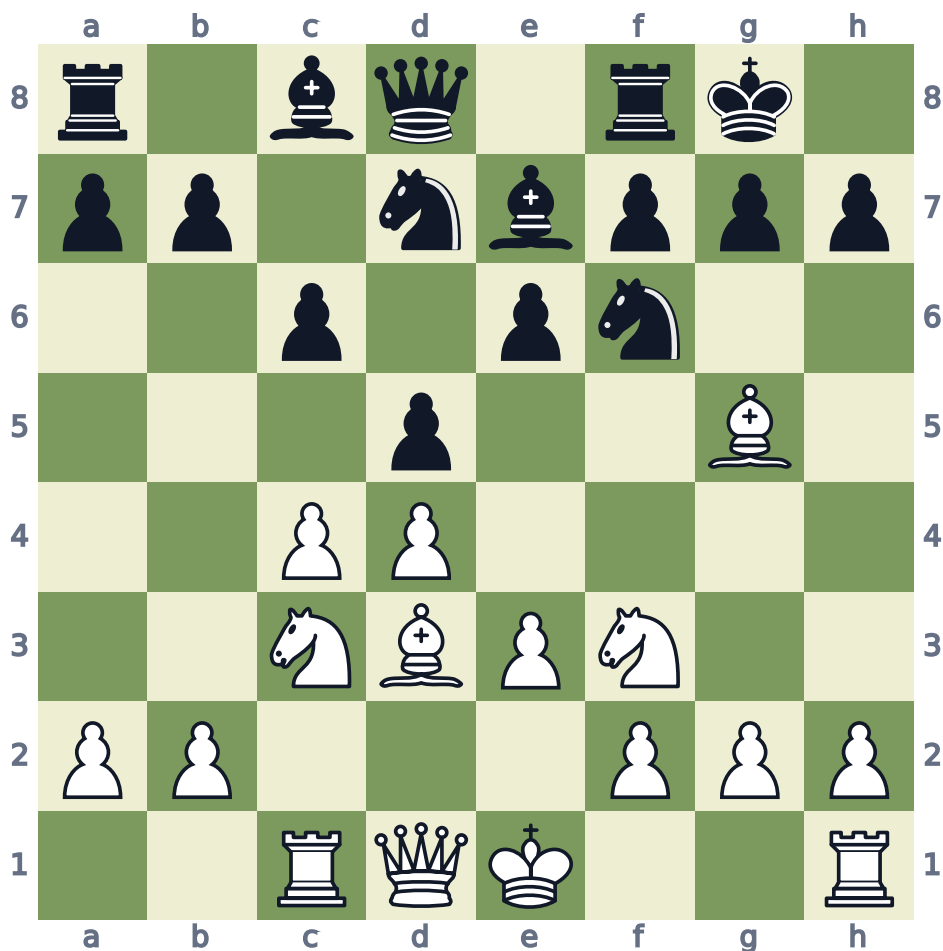
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 29 OF 30

Queen's Gambit Declined



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

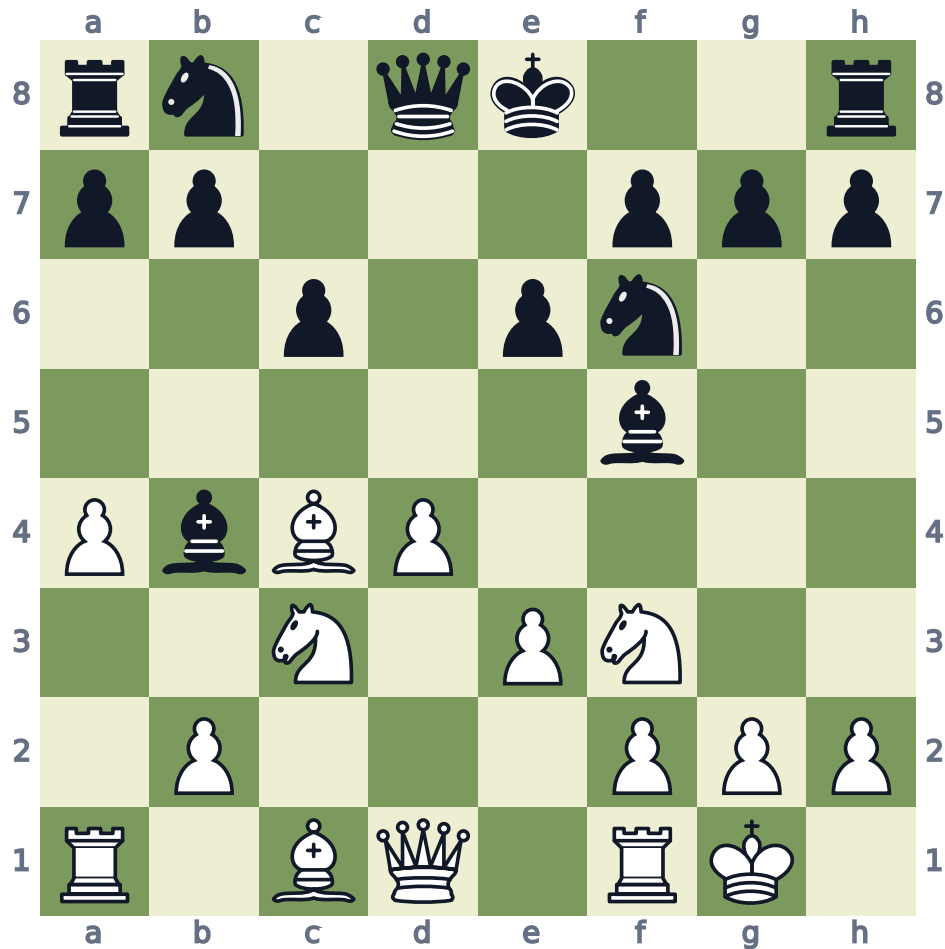
Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

PROBLEM 30 OF 30

Slav Defense



YOUR TASK

Evaluate the position: material, king safety, activity, pawn structure, space, initiative, worst piece, desired exchange, and best plan. Give a verdict before selecting a move.

DIFFICULTY

Full positional evaluation

BEFORE TURNING TO THE SOLUTION SECTION

Record candidates, the best defensive reply, and your final evaluation. A correct first move without a verified line earns only partial credit.

ANSWER SECTION

Solutions begin on the next page

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not browse the solution pages casually. Return to each problem, reconstruct the position, and compare the entire decision process. If your move matches but your line omits the best defense, score it as incomplete.

ERROR LABELS

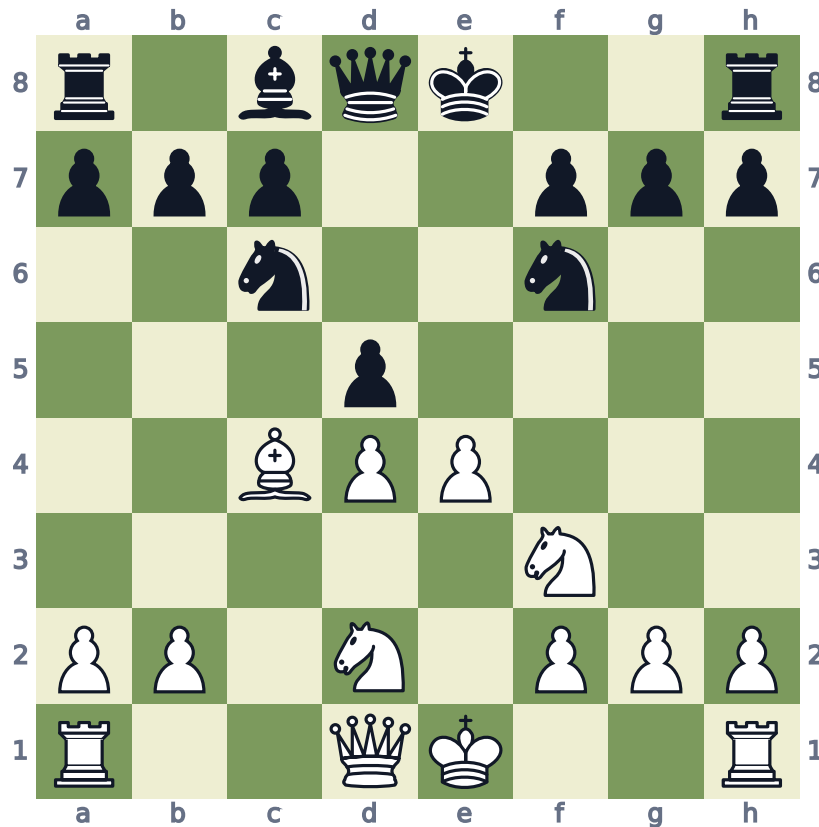
R = recognition error | C = candidate error | V = visualization error | D = missed defense | E = endpoint evaluation error | T = time-management error

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce one replacement question. Example: 'Before I calculate my attack, what countercheck does the opponent have?' Use that question in the next five slow games.

SOLUTION 01 OF 30

Italian Game



VERIFIED LINE

1. exd5 Nxd5 2. Qe2+ Be6 3. O-O O-O 4. h3 Nf4 5. Qe4 Bxc4

WHY IT WORKS

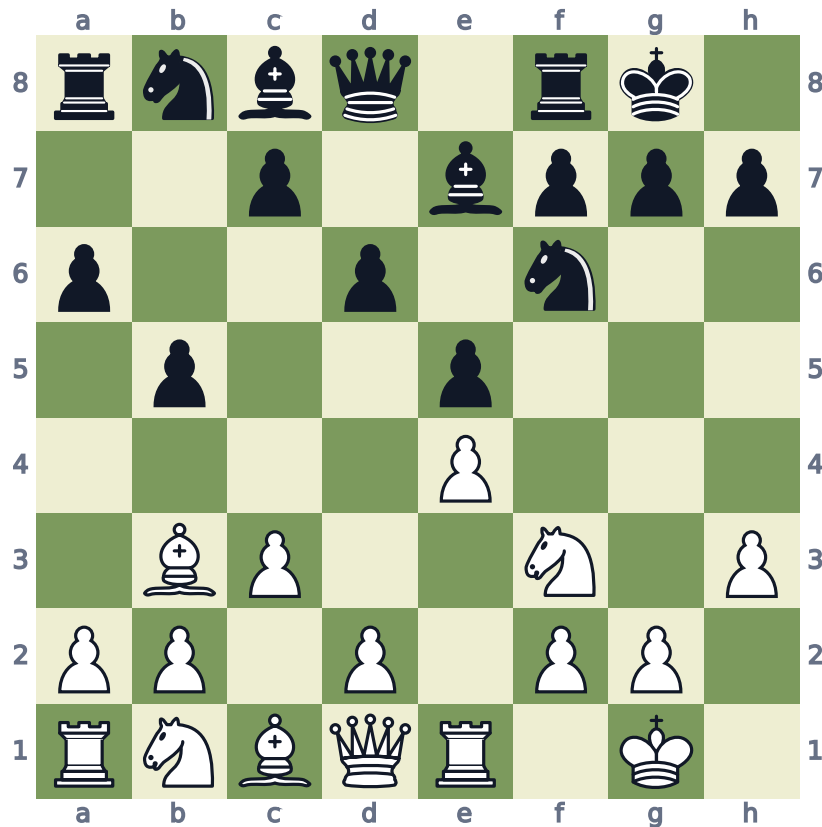
Approximate material: White 35, Black 35, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Build d4, castle, connect the rooks, and use e5 or d5 when the center allows it. Black plan: Meet d4 in the center, finish development, and avoid passive defense around f7. Thematic break: White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5. Engine line: 1. exd5 Nxd5 2. Qe2+ Be6 3. O-O O-O 4. h3 Nf4 5. Qe4 Bxc4 Evaluation: +0.11 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.11 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 02 OF 30

Ruy Lopez



VERIFIED LINE

1. a4 Bb7 2. d4 Nbd7 3. Nbd2 c5 4. d5 c4 5. Bc2 Nc5

WHY IT WORKS

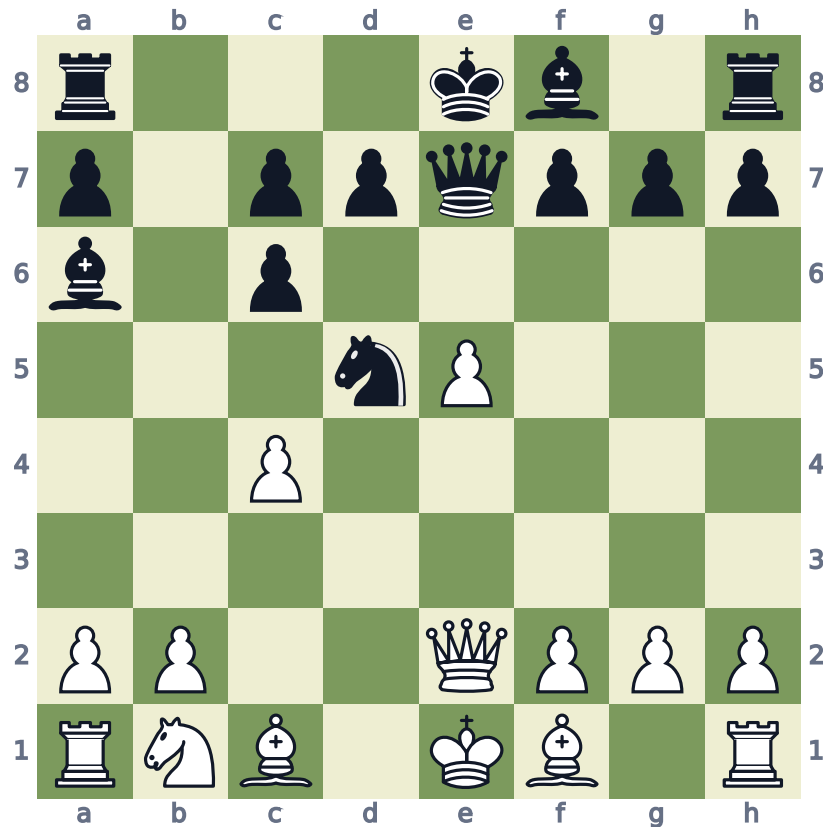
Approximate material: White 39, Black 39, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 1. White plan: Prepare d4 with c3, preserve the light bishop, and improve pieces before opening the center. Black plan: Gain space with ...b5, defend e5, and reorganize the queenside knight toward d7. Thematic break: White wants d4; Black often seeks ...d5 after enough preparation. Engine line: 1. a4 Bb7 2. d4 Nbd7 3. Nbd2 c5 4. d5 c4 5. Bc2 Nc5 Evaluation: +0.45 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.45 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 03 OF 30

Scotch Game



VERIFIED LINE

1. b3 f6 2. g3 fxe5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O e4 5. Nd2 d5

WHY IT WORKS

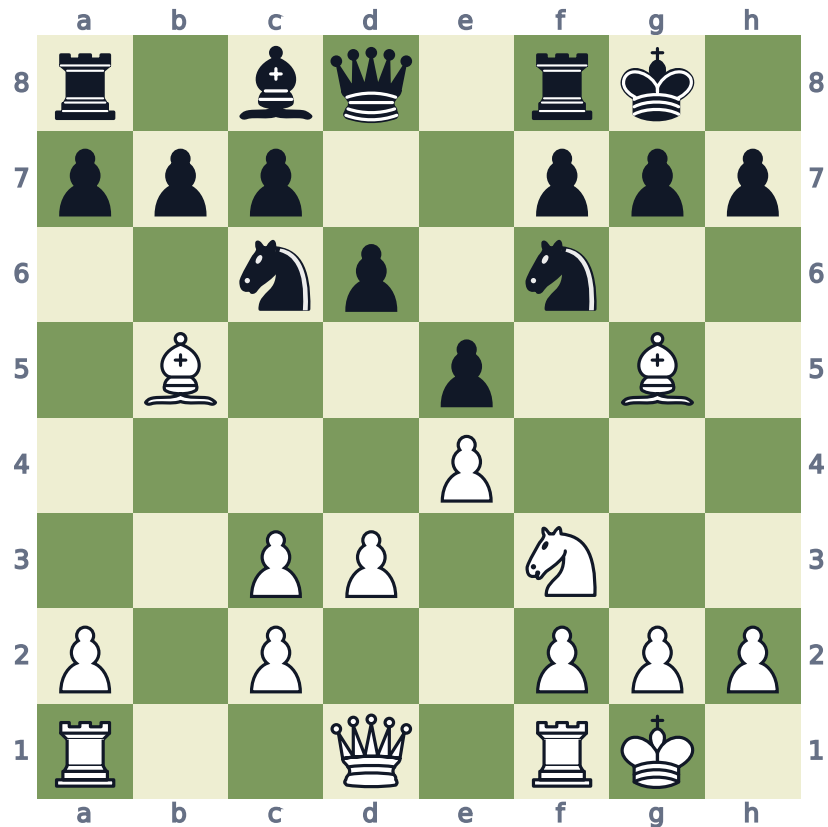
Approximate material: White 35, Black 35, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 3. White plan: Use the space from e5, develop rapidly, and target the altered queenside pawns. Black plan: Challenge e5, use open files and the bishop pair, and avoid falling behind in development. Thematic break: Black's ...d6 or ...d5 challenges White's advanced e-pawn. Engine line: 1. b3 f6 2. g3 fxe5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O e4 5. Nd2 d5 Evaluation: +0.29 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.29 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 04 OF 30

Four Knights Game



VERIFIED LINE

1. h6 Bh4 2. a6 Bxc6 3. bxc6 Qd2 4. Qe7 c4 5. Qe6

WHY IT WORKS

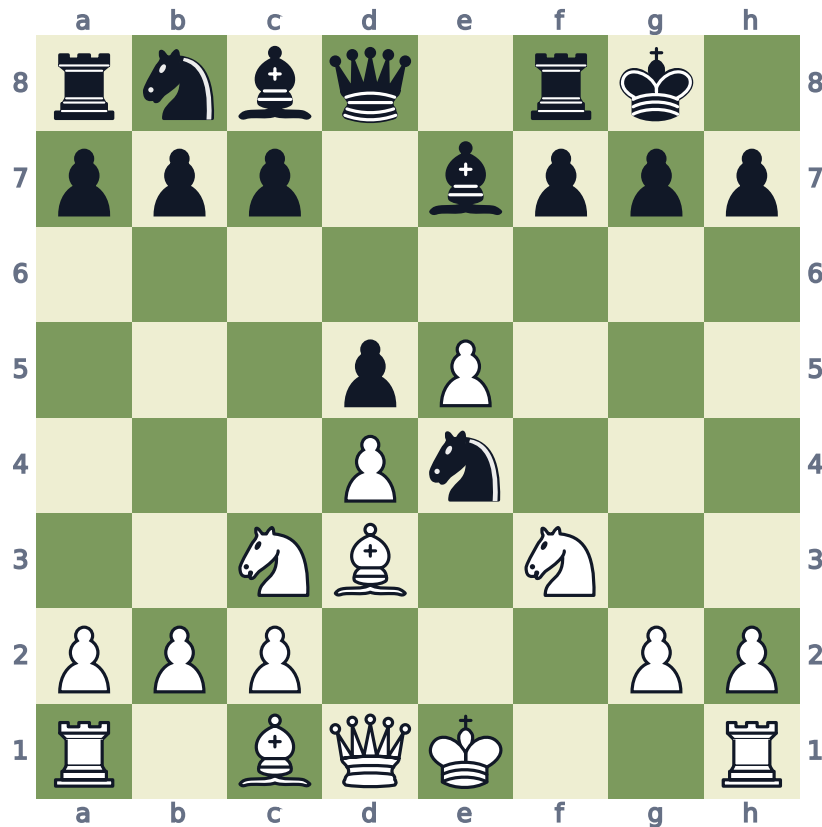
Approximate material: White 36, Black 36, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 1. White plan: Castle, choose d4 or a kingside buildup, and use the bishop pin to shape the center. Black plan: Match development, decide when to exchange on c3, and strike with ...d5 when possible. Thematic break: The d-pawn break by either side determines whether the game stays quiet. Engine line: 1. h6 Bh4 2. a6 Bxc6 3. bxc6 Qd2 4. Qe7 c4 5. Qe6 Evaluation: -0.14 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.14 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 05 OF 30

Vienna Game



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nxc3 bxc3 2. c5 O-O 3. c4 Be2 4. Nc6 h3 5. b5 Nh2

WHY IT WORKS

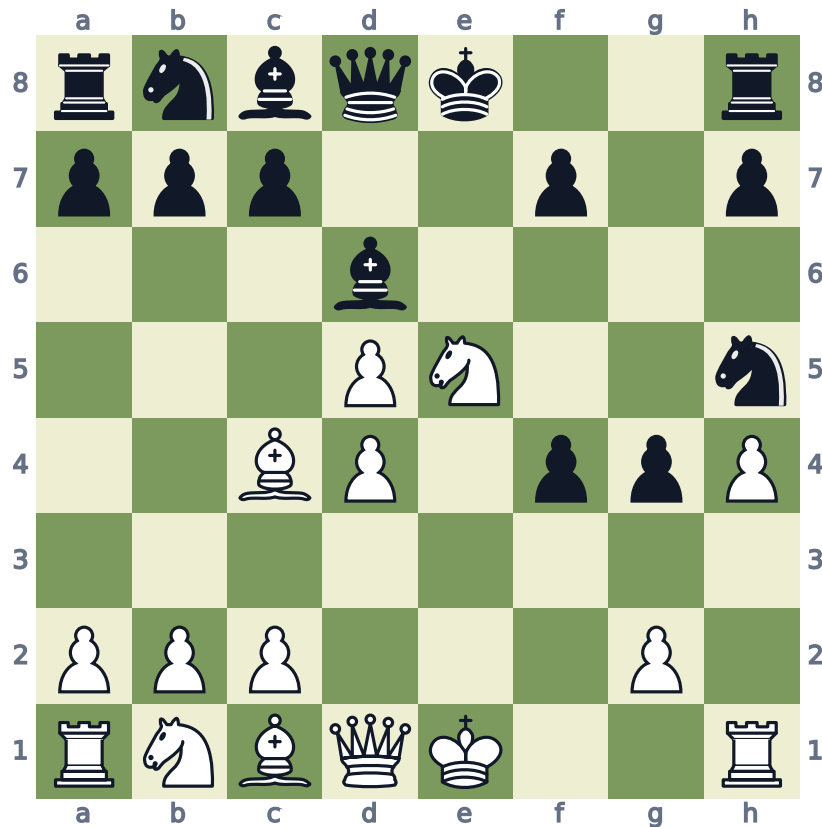
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Support e4, use f4 to challenge e5, and open lines only with pieces ready. Black plan: Counter in the center with ...d5 and make White prove the kingside expansion is safe. Thematic break: White's f4 is the signature break; Black's ...d5 is the principled reply. Engine line: 1. Nxc3 bxc3 2. c5 O-O 3. c4 Be2 4. Nc6 h3 5. b5 Nh2 Evaluation: +0.11 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.11 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 06 OF 30

King's Gambit



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nc3 O-O 2. Ne2 Qe7 3. Nxf4 Ng3 4. Ne6 fxe6 5. Bg5

WHY IT WORKS

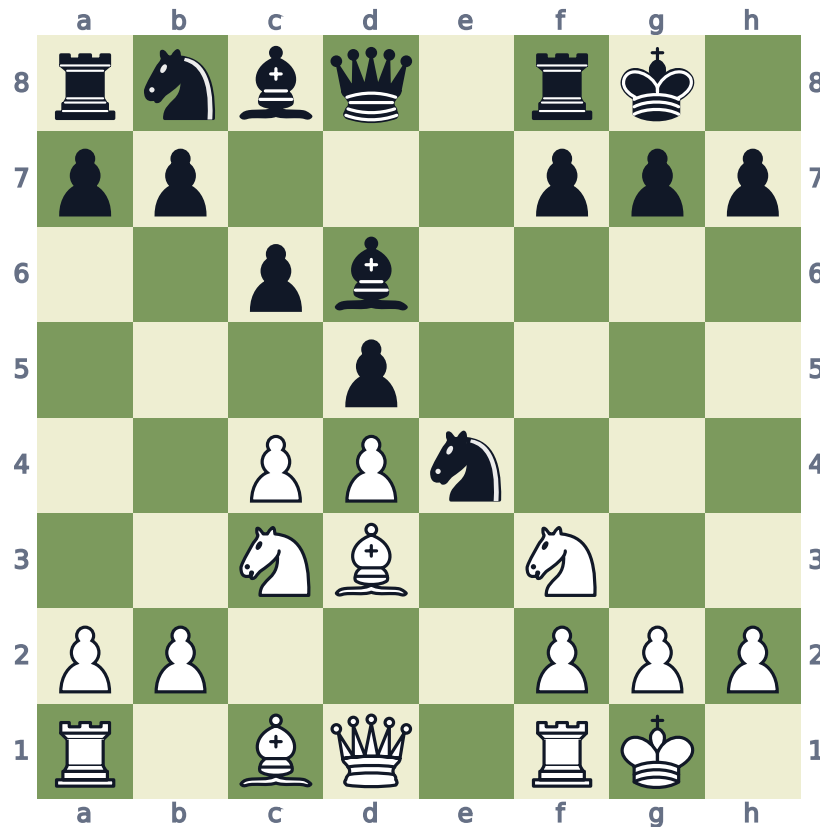
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Develop with tempo, recover control of the center, and open files toward the black king. Black plan: Keep the extra pawn only when safe, counter in the center, and return material to finish development. Thematic break: White's d4 restores central control; Black's ...d5 challenges the attacking setup. Engine line: 1. Nc3 O-O 2. Ne2 Qe7 3. Nxf4 Ng3 4. Ne6 fxe6 5. Bg5
Evaluation: -1.11 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -1.11 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 07 OF 30

Petrov Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nxc3 bxc3 2. dxc4 Bxc4 3. Bg4 h3 4. Bh5 g4 5. Bg6 Ne5

WHY IT WORKS

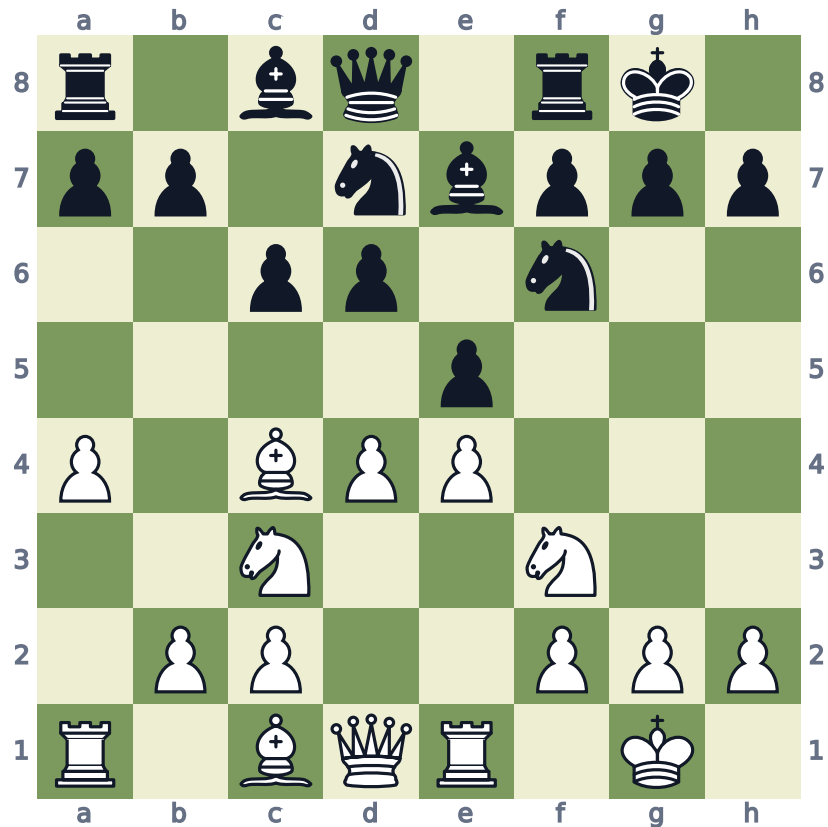
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Use the lead in space, challenge the e4-knight, and create an isolated-pawn or open-center target. Black plan: Return the pawn correctly, centralize, and use the symmetrical structure without drifting. Thematic break: c4 challenges Black's d5 anchor; ...c6 reinforces or prepares a later queenside expansion. Engine line: 1. Nxc3 bxc3 2. dxc4 Bxc4 3. Bg4 h3 4. Bh5 g4 5. Bg6 Ne5 Evaluation: -0.33 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.33 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 08 OF 30

Philidor Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. exd4 Nxd4 2. Ne5 Ba2 3. Ng6 h3 4. Re8 Be3 5. Bd7 f4

WHY IT WORKS

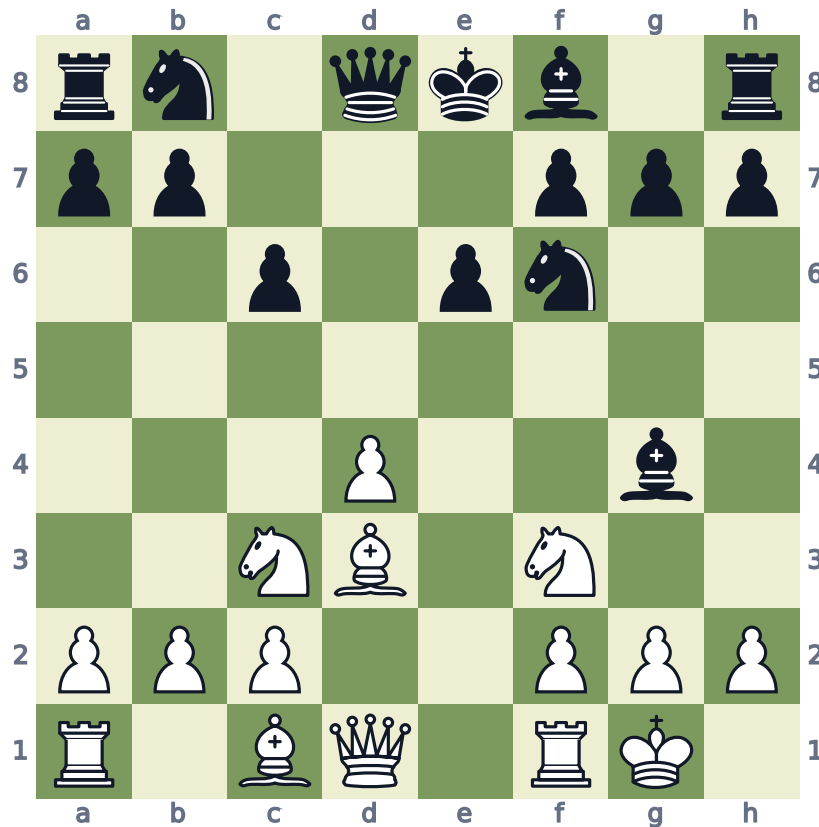
Approximate material: White 39, Black 39, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 1. White plan: Use space, develop smoothly, and prevent Black's freeing breaks from arriving comfortably. Black plan: Finish development, support e5, and prepare ...c6 with ...Qc7 or the freeing ...d5. Thematic break: Black needs ...d5 or sometimes ...c6 and ...b5 to avoid permanent congestion. Engine line: 1. exd4 Nxd4 2. Ne5 Ba2 3. Ng6 h3 4. Re8 Be3 5. Bd7 f4 Evaluation: -0.60 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.60 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 09 OF 30

Scandinavian Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. a4 a5 2. Ne4 Nxe4 3. Bxe4 Nd7 4. h3 Bh5 5. g4 Bg6

WHY IT WORKS

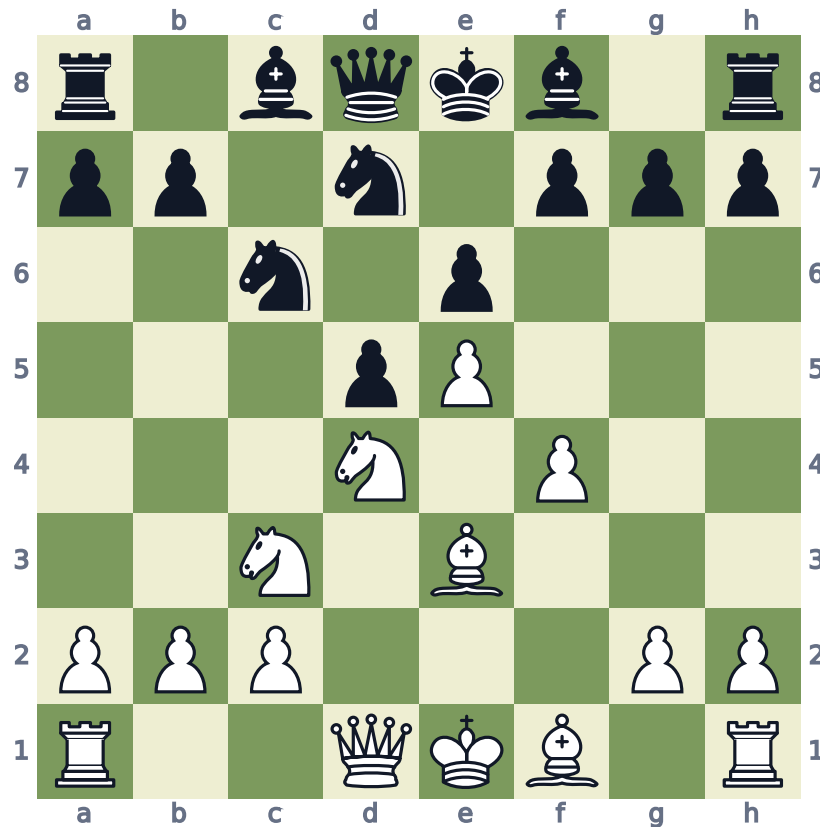
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Develop with tempo, occupy the center, and use the space lead before it disappears. Black plan: Place the queen safely, build a light-square structure, and finish development without more lost tempi. Thematic break: Black's ...c5 challenges d4; White may use d5 if development supports the advance. Engine line: 1. a4 a5 2. Ne4 Nxe4 3. Bxe4 Nd7 4. h3 Bh5 5. g4 Bg6 Evaluation: +0.36 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.36 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 10 OF 30

French Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. Qb6 Qd2 2. Qxb2 Rb1 3. Qa3 Rb3 4. Qa5 Ncb5 5. Qxd2+ Kxd2

WHY IT WORKS

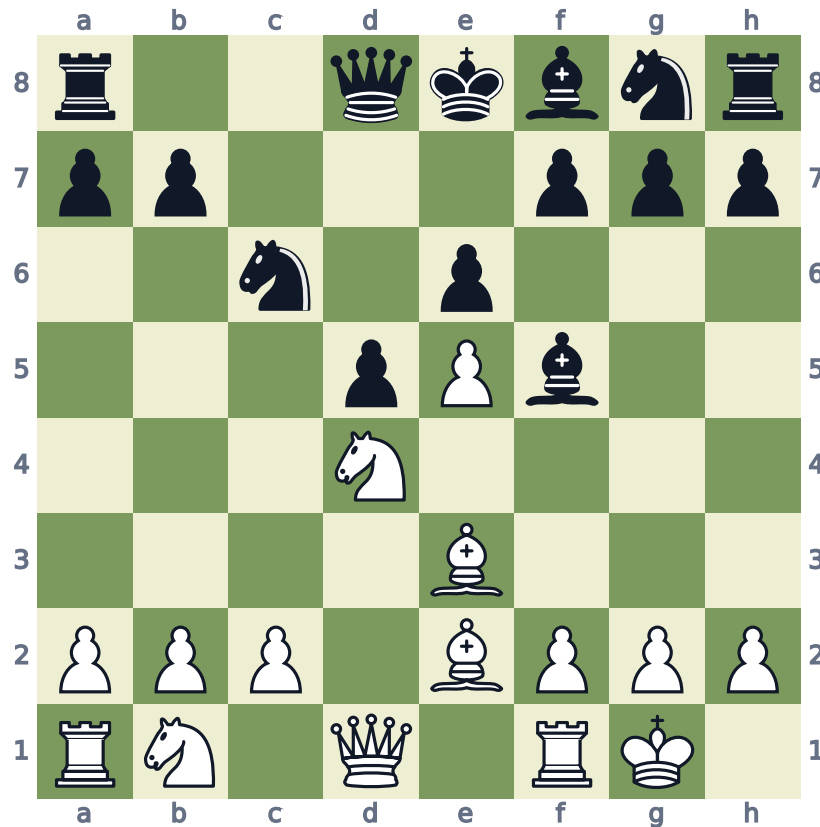
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Support e5, develop the queenside, and attack where the pawn chain points. Black plan: Attack d4 with ...c5, challenge e5 with ...f6, and activate the c8-bishop deliberately. Thematic break: ...c5 is essential; ...f6 is the second lever against White's center. Engine line: 1. Qb6 Qd2 2. Qxb2 Rb1 3. Qa3 Rb3 4. Qa5 Ncb5 5. Qxd2+ Kxd2 Evaluation: -0.32 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.32 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 11 OF 30

Caro-Kann Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nxd4 Qxd4 2. Ne7 Bb5+ 3. Nc6 c4 4. Be7 cxd5 5. Qxd5 Qa4

WHY IT WORKS

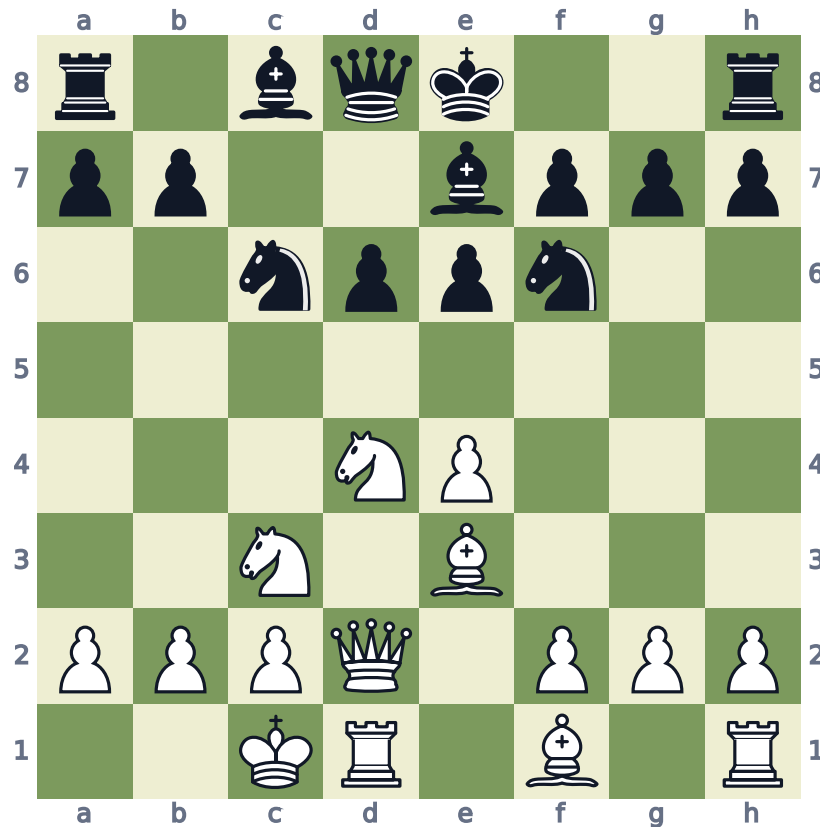
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Use space, develop without blocking the center, and respond accurately to ...c5. Black plan: Complete development, challenge d4, and avoid allowing e5 to become untouchable. Thematic break: ...c5 is the main equalizing lever; ...f6 may attack e5 later. Engine line: 1. Nxd4 Qxd4 2. Ne7 Bb5+ 3. Nc6 c4 4. Be7 cxd5 5. Qxd5 Qa4 Evaluation: -0.23 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.23 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 12 OF 30

Open Sicilian



VERIFIED LINE

1. Ng4 Ndb5 2. a6 Nxd6+ 3. Qxd6 Qxd6 4. Bxd6 Rxd6 5. Nxe3 fxe3

WHY IT WORKS

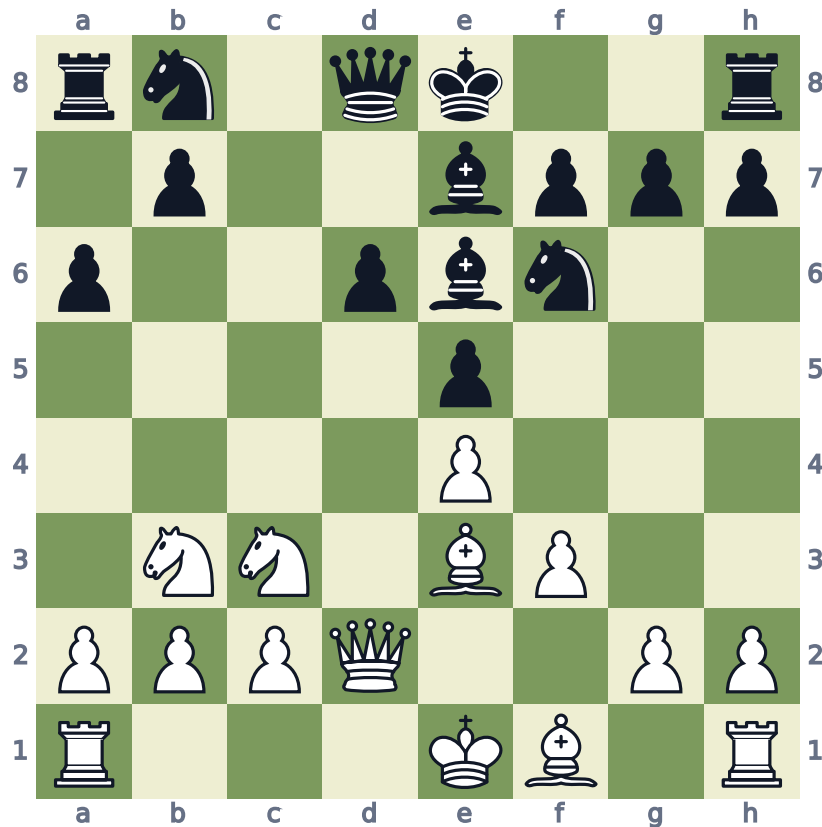
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Develop quickly, use the d-file and kingside space, and decide where the king belongs. Black plan: Pressure d4, use the c-file, and counter on the queenside before White's attack lands. Thematic break: White often uses f4-f5; Black often uses ...d5 or ...b5-b4. Engine line: 1. Ng4 Ndb5 2. a6 Nxd6+ 3. Qxd6 Qxd6 4. Bxd6 Rxd6 5. Nxe3 fxe3 Evaluation: -0.17 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.17 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 13 OF 30

Sicilian Najdorf



VERIFIED LINE

1. h5 Nd5 2. Nxd5 exd5 3. Bf5 O-O-O 4. Nd7 Kb1 5. Rc8 Bd3

WHY IT WORKS

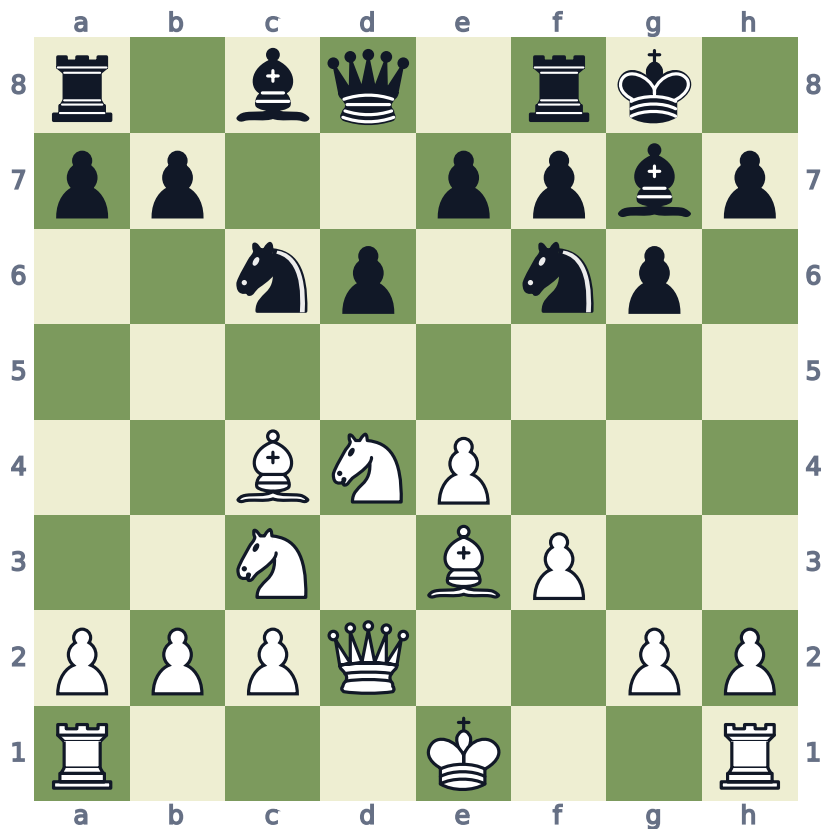
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Choose a clear setup, finish queenside development, and attack before Black completes counterplay. Black plan: Use ...b5, pressure the center, and pick ...e5 or ...e6 according to White's setup. Thematic break: ...b5-b4 is thematic; White often uses g4-g5 or f4-f5. Engine line: 1. h5 Nd5 2. Nxd5 exd5 3. Bf5 O-O-O 4. Nd7 Kb1 5. Rc8 Bd3 Evaluation: -0.20 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.20 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 14 OF 30

Sicilian Dragon



VERIFIED LINE

1. Bd7 O-O-O 2. a6 Bb3 3. b5 h4 4. b4 Nd5 5. a5 h5

WHY IT WORKS

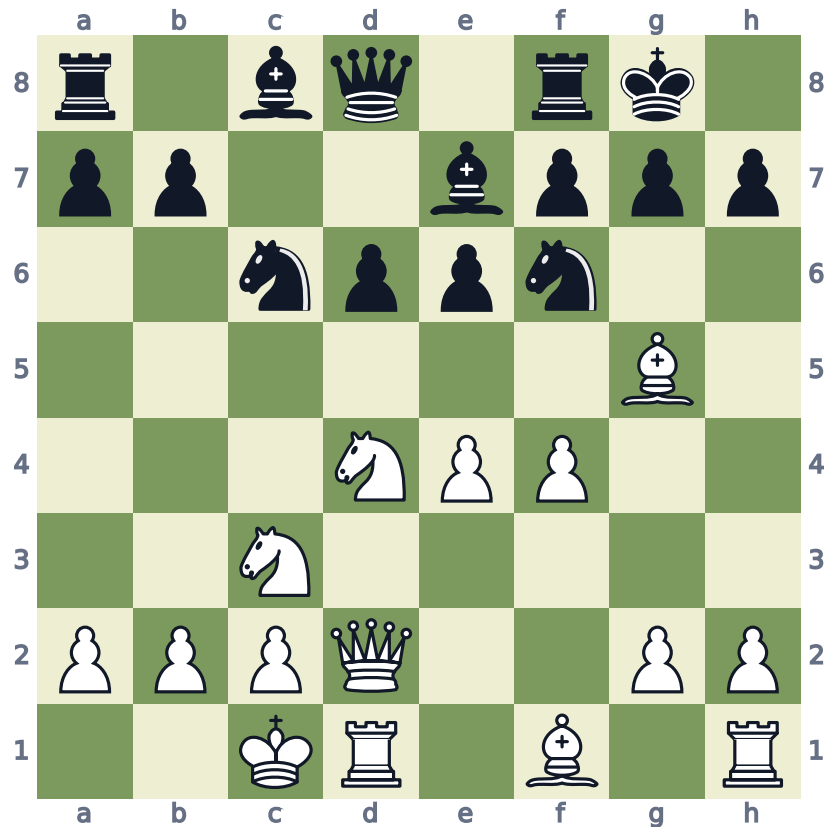
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Castle long, trade the g7-bishop when useful, and push the h-pawn with full development. Black plan: Use the c-file, pressure c3, and create queenside counterplay with ...b5. Thematic break: White's h4-h5 and Black's ...b5 are the race-defining breaks. Engine line: 1. Bd7 O-O-O 2. a6 Bb3 3. b5 h4 4. b4 Nd5 5. a5 h5 Evaluation: -0.69 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.69 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 15 OF 30

Classical Sicilian



VERIFIED LINE

1. h6 Bh4 2. e5 Nxc6 3. bxc6 fxe5 4. dxe5 Qxd8 5. Rxd8 Rxd8+

WHY IT WORKS

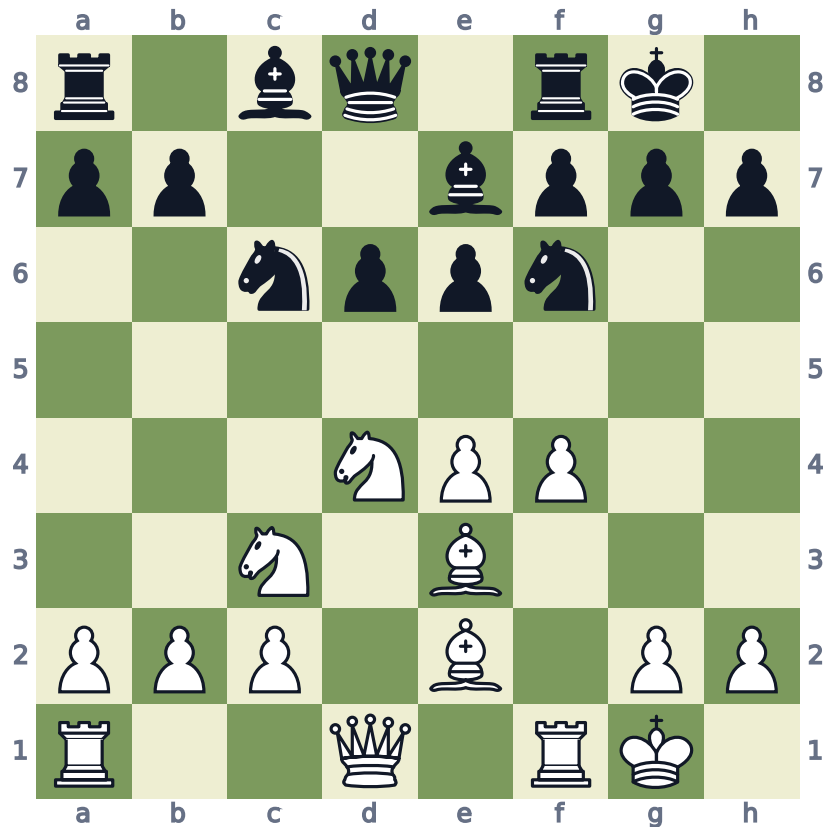
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Use the pin, castle long when appropriate, and build f4-f5 with piece support. Black plan: Break the pin, pressure d4, and seek ...d5 or queenside play. Thematic break: White's f5 challenges e6; Black's ...d5 is the cleanest freeing break. Engine line: 1. h6 Bh4 2. e5 Nxc6 3. bxc6 fxe5 4. dxe5 Qxd8 5. Rxd8 Rxd8+ Evaluation: -0.44 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.44 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 16 OF 30

Sicilian Scheveningen



VERIFIED LINE

1. e5 Nxc6 2. bxc6 fxe5 3. dxe5 Qe1 4. Ng4 Bxg4 5. Bxg4 Qg3

WHY IT WORKS

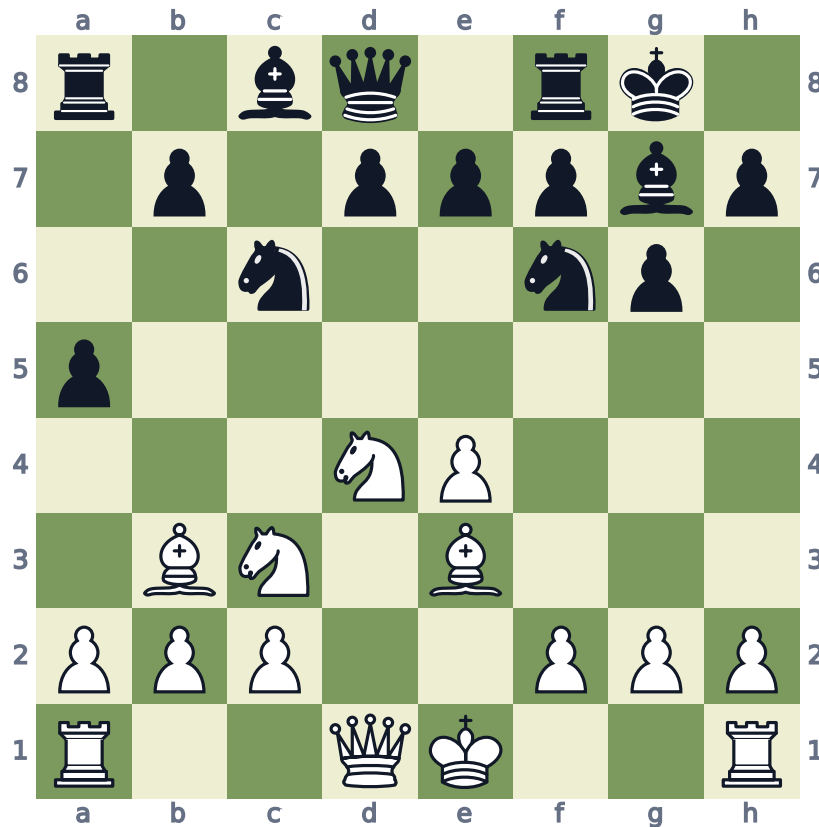
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Use f4, coordinate against the king, and watch the e5-square. Black plan: Complete development, use ...Qc7 and ...b5, and time ...d5 precisely. Thematic break: White's f5 and Black's ...d5 or ...b5 are the critical levers. Engine line: 1. e5 Nxc6 2. bxc6 fxe5 3. dxe5 Qe1 4. Ng4 Bxg4 5. Bxg4 Qg3 Evaluation: -0.25 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.25 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 17 OF 30

Accelerated Dragon



VERIFIED LINE

1. a4 Ng4 2. Qxg4 Nxd4 3. Qh4 Bf6 4. Qg3 Nxb3 5. cxb3 d6

WHY IT WORKS

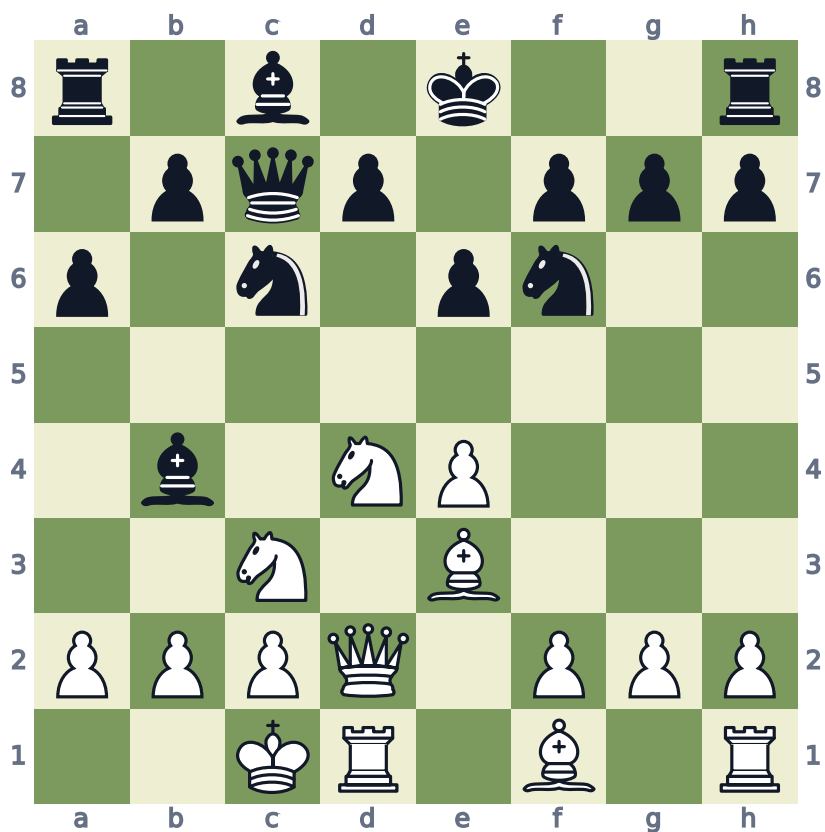
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Control d5, consider the Maroczy structure with c4, and avoid routine attacking moves. Black plan: Use rapid activity, pressure d4, and strike with ...d5 when tactically sound. Thematic break: ...d5 is the opening's central question; White's c4 can restrain it. Engine line: 1. a4 Ng4 2. Qxg4 Nxd4 3. Qh4 Bf6 4. Qg3 Nxb3 5. cxb3 d6 Evaluation: +0.38 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.38 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 18 OF 30

Sicilian Taimanov



VERIFIED LINE

1. f3 d5 2. a3 Ba5 3. Nb3 Bxc3 4. Qxc3 O-O 5. Nd4 dxe4

WHY IT WORKS

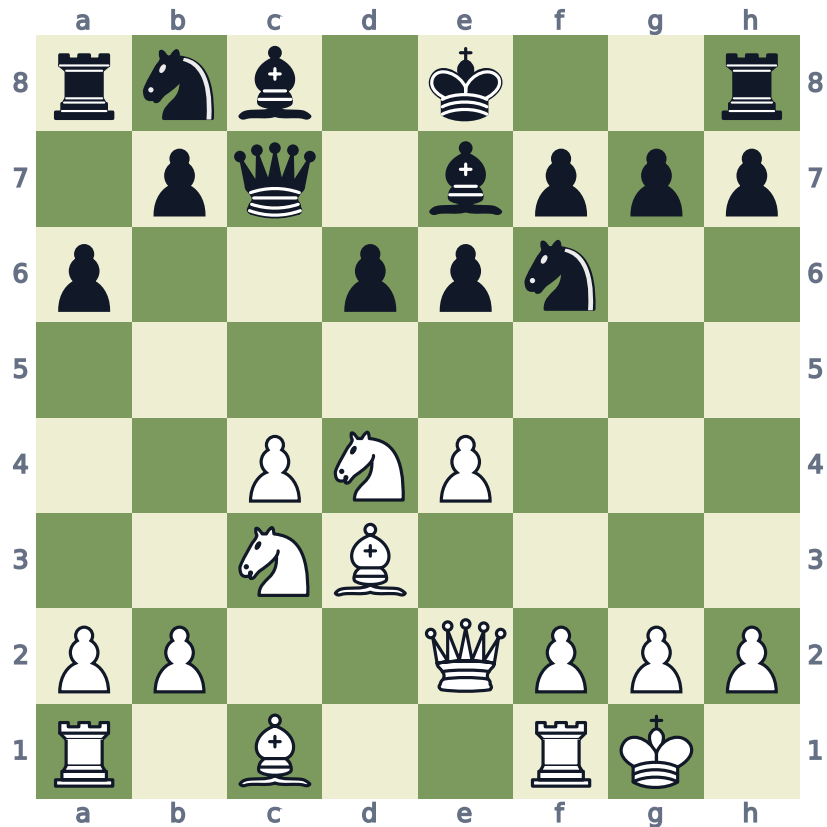
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Develop quickly, decide between long castling and a quieter setup, and watch ...Bb4. Black plan: Use ...a6 and ...b5, pressure c3 and e4, and prepare ...Nf6 or ...d5. Thematic break: Black's ...d5 is ideal; ...b5 creates the usual queenside space. Engine line: 1. f3 d5 2. a3 Ba5 3. Nb3 Bxc3 4. Qxc3 O-O 5. Nd4 dxe4 Evaluation: +0.69 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.69 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 19 OF 30

Sicilian Kan



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nc6 Nxc6 2. bxc6 f4 3. Nd7 Rf3 4. c5 Rh3 5. Bb7 Bd2

WHY IT WORKS

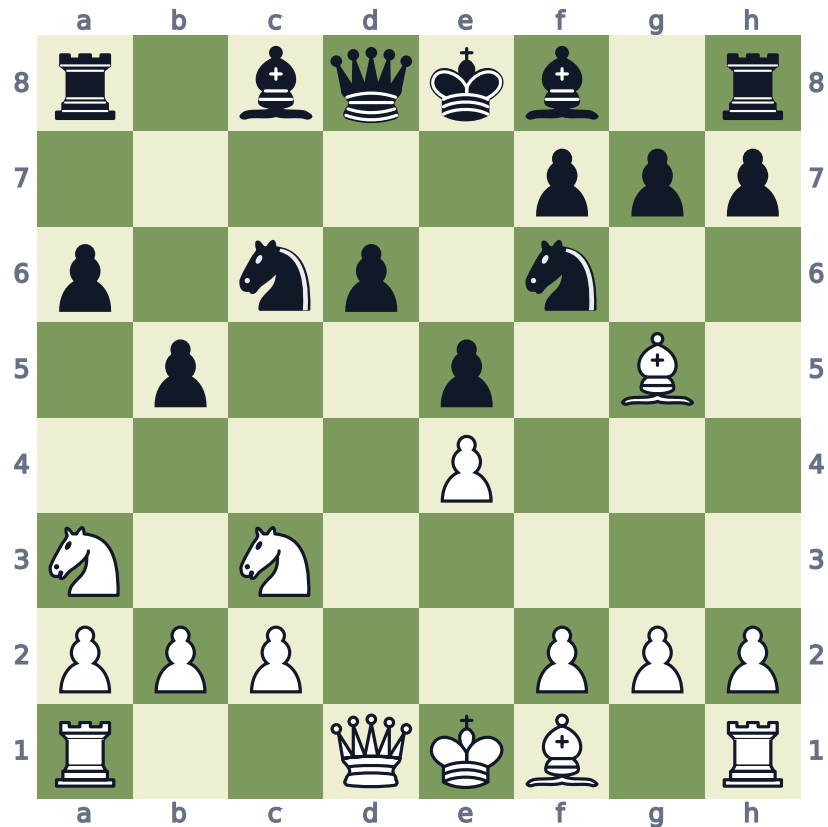
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Claim space with c4 when useful, finish development, and prevent an easy ...d5. Black plan: Use ...b5, choose the best square for the b8-knight, and challenge White's space later. Thematic break: ...b5 is thematic; ...d5 is the freeing central goal. Engine line: 1. Nc6 Nxc6 2. bxc6 f4 3. Nd7 Rf3 4. c5 Rh3 5. Bb7 Bd2 Evaluation: -0.61 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.61 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 20 OF 30

Sicilian Sveshnikov



VERIFIED LINE

1. Bxf6 gxf6 2. Nd5 f5 3. Bd3 Be6 4. O-O Bxd5 5. exd5 Ne7

WHY IT WORKS

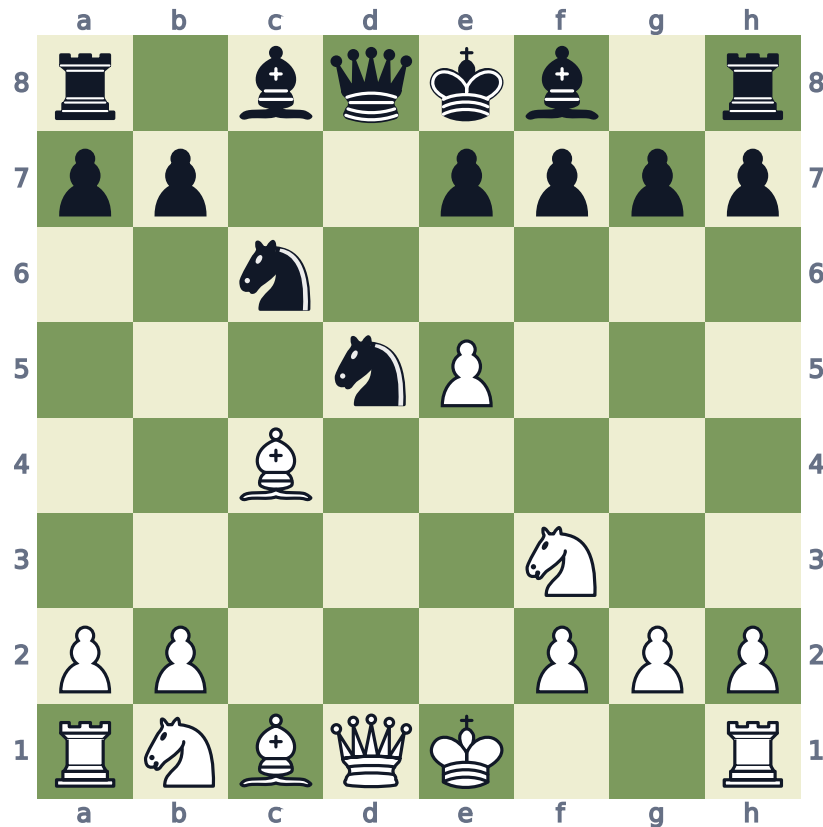
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Use d5 as an outpost, pressure d6, and stop Black's active pawn expansion. Black plan: Gain space with ...b5 and ...f5, use active pieces, and avoid passive defense of weaknesses. Thematic break: ...f5 energizes Black's kingside; White often uses c3 and Nc2-e3-d5. Engine line: 1. Bxf6 gxf6 2. Nd5 f5 3. Bd3 Be6 4. O-O Bxd5 5. exd5 Ne7 Evaluation: +0.50 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.50 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 21 OF 30

Sicilian Alapin



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nb6 Qxd8+ 2. Nxd8 Bb5+ 3. Bd7 Nc3 4. Bxb5 Nxb5 5. Nd5 Ke2

WHY IT WORKS

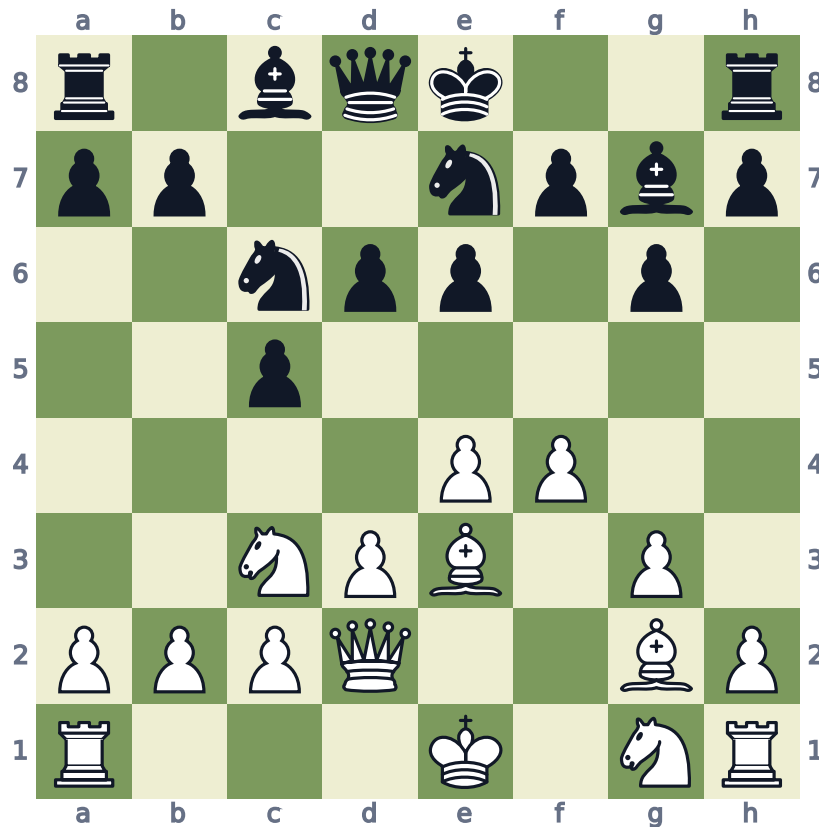
Approximate material: White 37, Black 37, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Build the center, develop behind it, and use space without overprotecting every pawn. Black plan: Attack e4 immediately, exchange central pawns, and make White prove the center is stable. Thematic break: Black's ...d5 or ...d6 attacks the center; White may advance e5 for space. Engine line: 1. Nb6 Qxd8+ 2. Nxd8 Bb5+ 3. Bd7 Nc3 4. Bxb5 Nxb5 5. Nd5 Ke2 Evaluation: -0.24 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.24 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 22 OF 30

Closed Sicilian



VERIFIED LINE

1. O-O Nf3 2. Rb8 O-O 3. b5 Rab1 4. a5

WHY IT WORKS

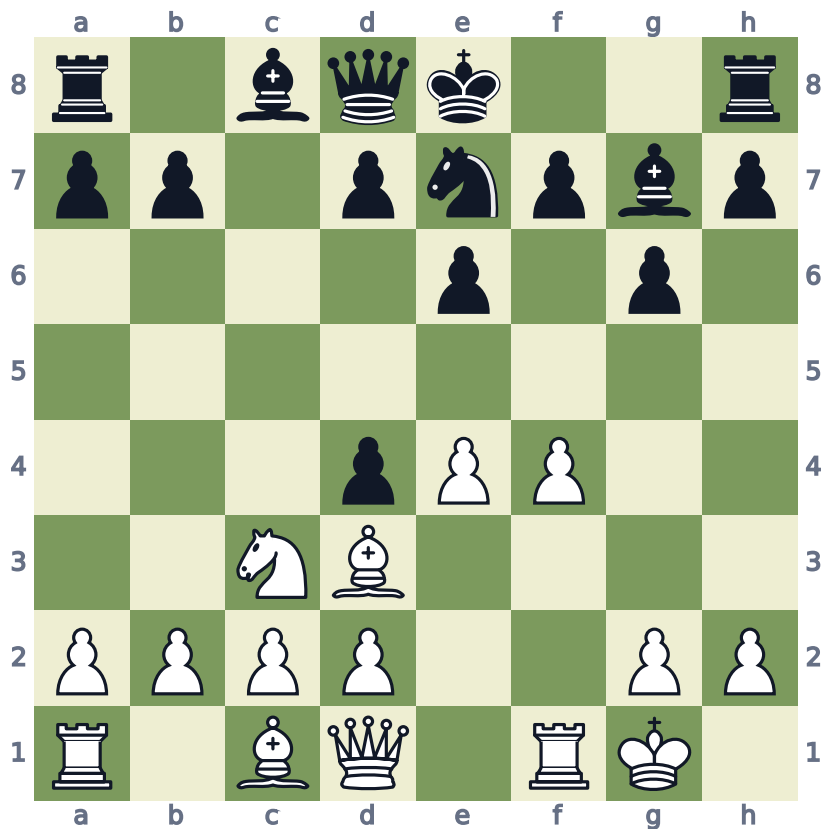
Approximate material: White 39, Black 39, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 1. White plan: Fianchetto, castle, use f4-f5, and keep queenside counterplay under observation. Black plan: Expand with ...Rb8 and ...b5, challenge d4 or e5, and avoid waiting passively. Thematic break: White's f5 and Black's ...b5 create the two-wing race. Engine line: 1. O-O Nf3 2. Rb8 O-O 3. b5 Rab1 4. a5 Evaluation: +0.33 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.33 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 23 OF 30

Grand Prix Attack



VERIFIED LINE

1. Ne2 f5 2. exf5 Nxf5 3. b3 b5 4. Ng3 Bb7

WHY IT WORKS

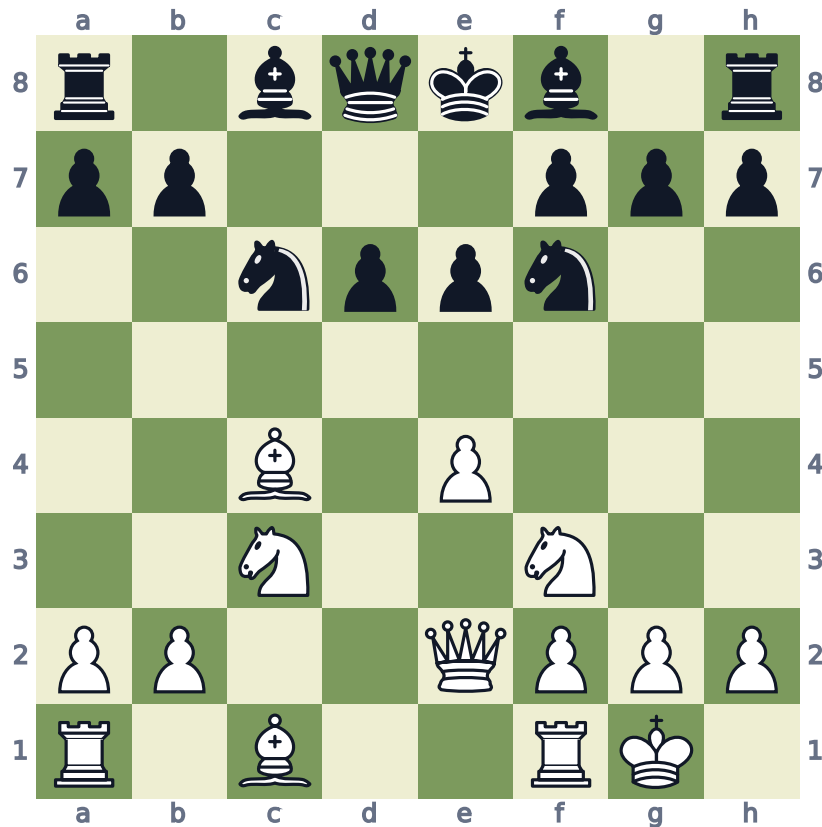
Approximate material: White 36, Black 36, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 2. White plan: Castle, place the queen toward e1-h4, and use f5 only when pieces support it. Black plan: Counter in the center, use ...d5, and make the b5-bishop decide its future. Thematic break: White's f5 is thematic; Black's ...d5 is the central antidote. Engine line: 1. Ne2 f5 2. exf5 Nxf5 3. b3 b5 4. Ng3 Bb7 Evaluation: -0.05 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.05 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 24 OF 30

Smith-Morra Gambit



VERIFIED LINE

1. Be7 Rd1 2. e5 Bg5 3. O-O

WHY IT WORKS

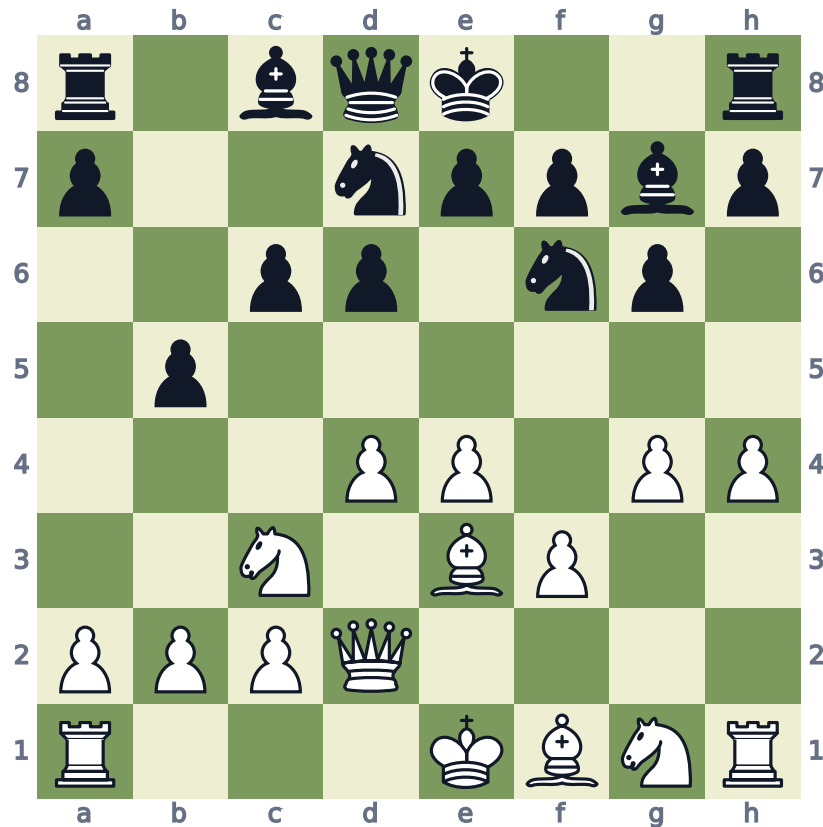
Approximate material: White 37, Black 38, difference -1. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Put rooks on open files, develop every piece, and attack before queens are traded. Black plan: Complete development, return material if necessary, and blunt White's activity with accurate defense. Thematic break: White may use e5; Black often seeks ...d5 to neutralize the initiative. Engine line: 1. Be7 Rd1 2. e5 Bg5 3. O-O Evaluation: +0.38 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.38 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 25 OF 30

Pirc Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. h5 g5 2. Nh7 f4 3. Nb6 Qf2 4. O-O

WHY IT WORKS

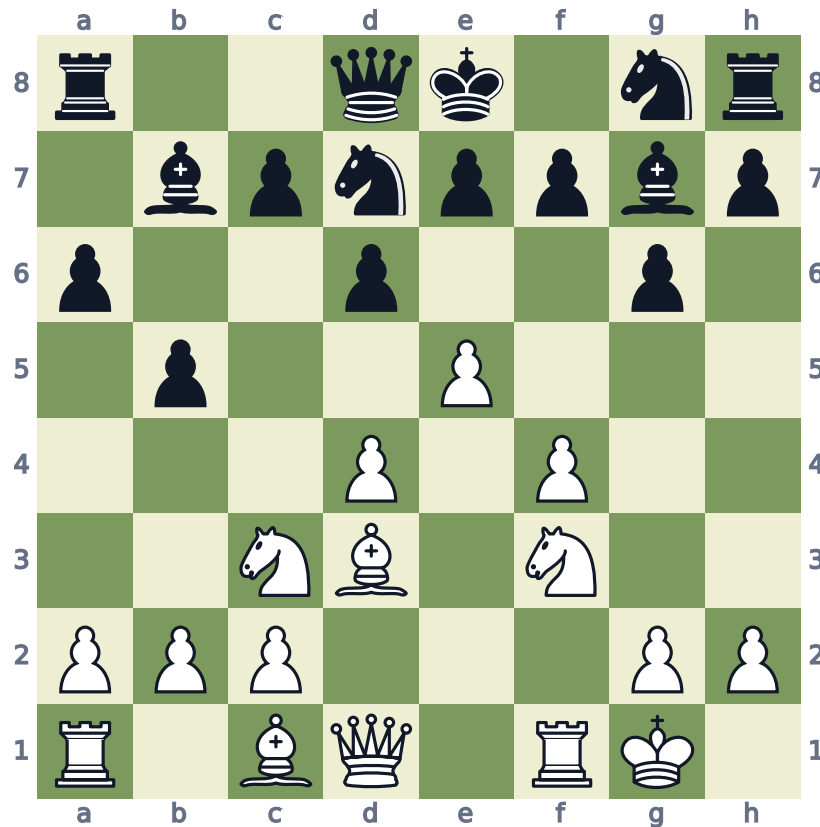
Approximate material: White 39, Black 39, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 1. White plan: Use the space responsibly, choose a setup, and avoid creating targets faster than threats. Black plan: Fianchetto, strike with ...e5 or ...c5, and create queenside play against an overextended center. Thematic break: Black's ...e5 or ...c5 challenges the center; White often uses f4-f5 or h4-h5. Engine line: 1. h5 g5 2. Nh7 f4 3. Nb6 Qf2 4. O-O Evaluation: -0.38 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.38 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 26 OF 30

Modern Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. Nh6 a4 2. b4 Ne4 3. O-O Neg5 4. e6 Ne4 5. Nf5 c3

WHY IT WORKS

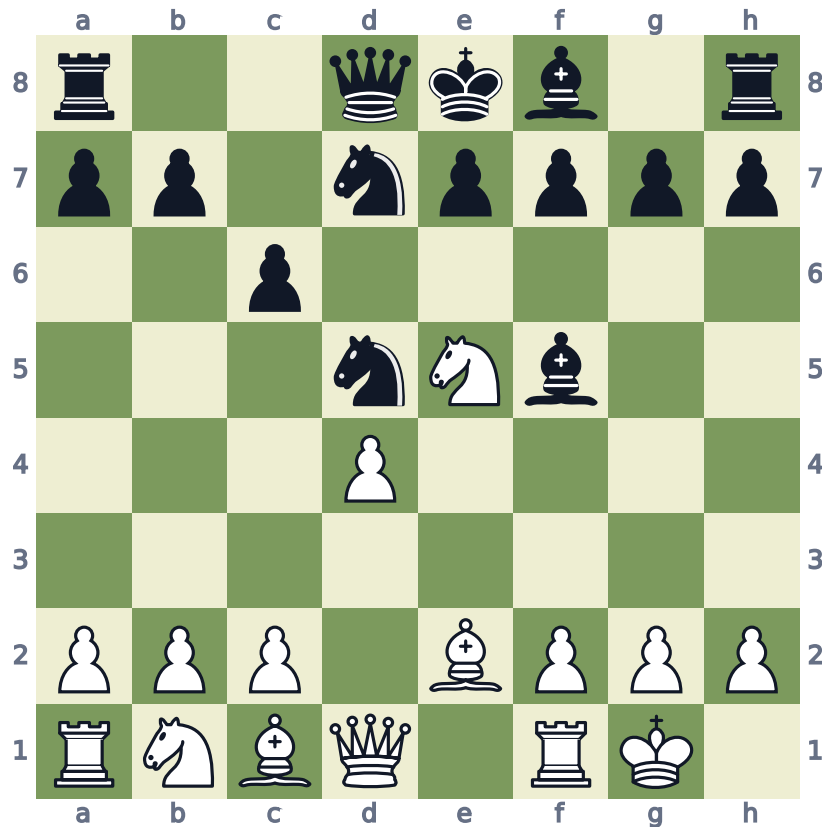
Approximate material: White 39, Black 39, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 1. White plan: Occupy the center, develop behind it, and expand only when the king is safe. Black plan: Attack the center with ...c5 or ...e5 and use queenside space without neglecting development. Thematic break: ...c5 and ...e5 are Black's key choices; White's e5 can gain space and time. Engine line: 1. Nh6 a4 2. b4 Ne4 3. O-O Neg5 4. e6 Ne4 5. Nf5 c3 Evaluation: -0.54 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.54 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 27 OF 30

Alekhine Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. g4 Be6 2. f4 Nxe5 3. fxe5 Nc7 4. c4 g6 5. Nc3 Bg7

WHY IT WORKS

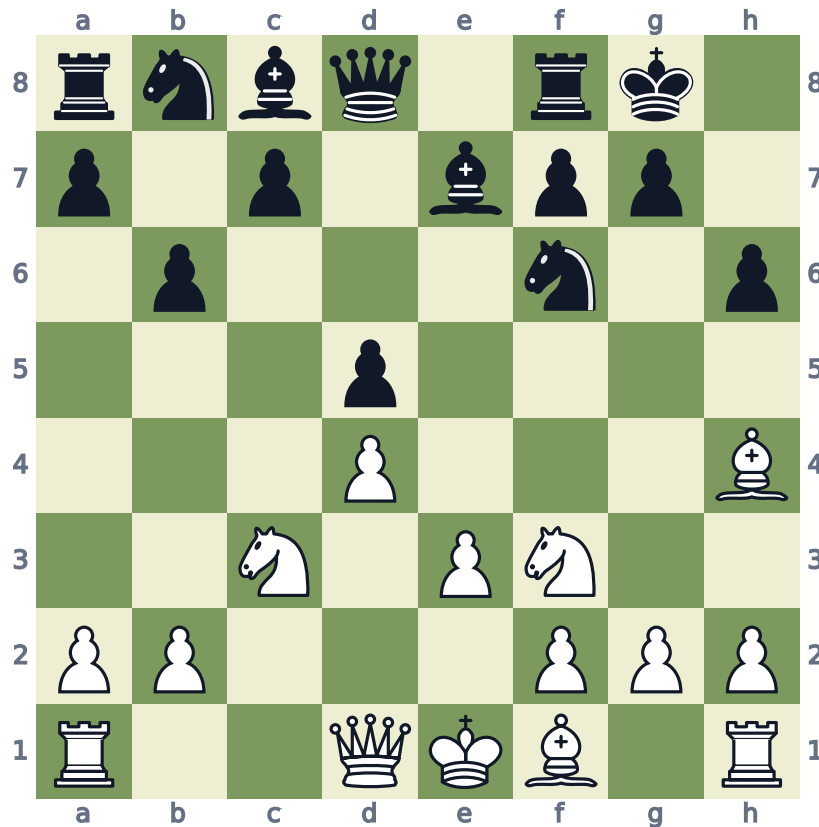
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Use the space but support it with pieces, not endless pawn moves. Black plan: Challenge e5 and d4, exchange central pawns, and develop without getting trapped. Thematic break: ...d6 is the first challenge; ...c5 adds pressure to d4. Engine line: 1. g4 Be6 2. f4 Nxe5 3. fxe5 Nc7 4. c4 g6 5. Nc3 Bg7 Evaluation: +0.54 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.54 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 28 OF 30

Queen's Gambit



VERIFIED LINE

1. Ne5 Bb7 2. Bb5 c5 3. O-O a6 4. Ba4 b5 5. Bc2 c4

WHY IT WORKS

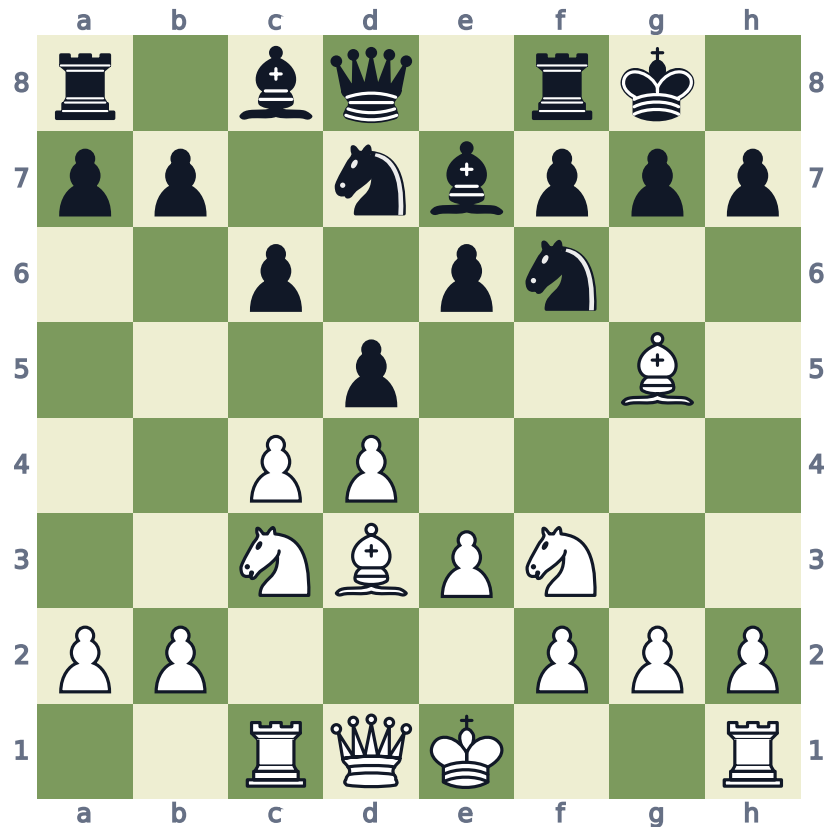
Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Develop, choose the right central exchange, and use queenside space or a minority attack. Black plan: Maintain or resolve the center, free the c8-bishop, and contest the c-file. Thematic break: White's cxd5 may create a Carlsbad structure; Black wants ...c5. Engine line: 1. Ne5 Bb7 2. Bb5 c5 3. O-O a6 4. Ba4 b5 5. Bc2 c4 Evaluation: +0.42 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: +0.42 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 29 OF 30

Queen's Gambit Declined



VERIFIED LINE

1. dxc4 Bxc4 2. a6 O-O 3. b5 Bxf6 4. Nxf6 Bd3

WHY IT WORKS

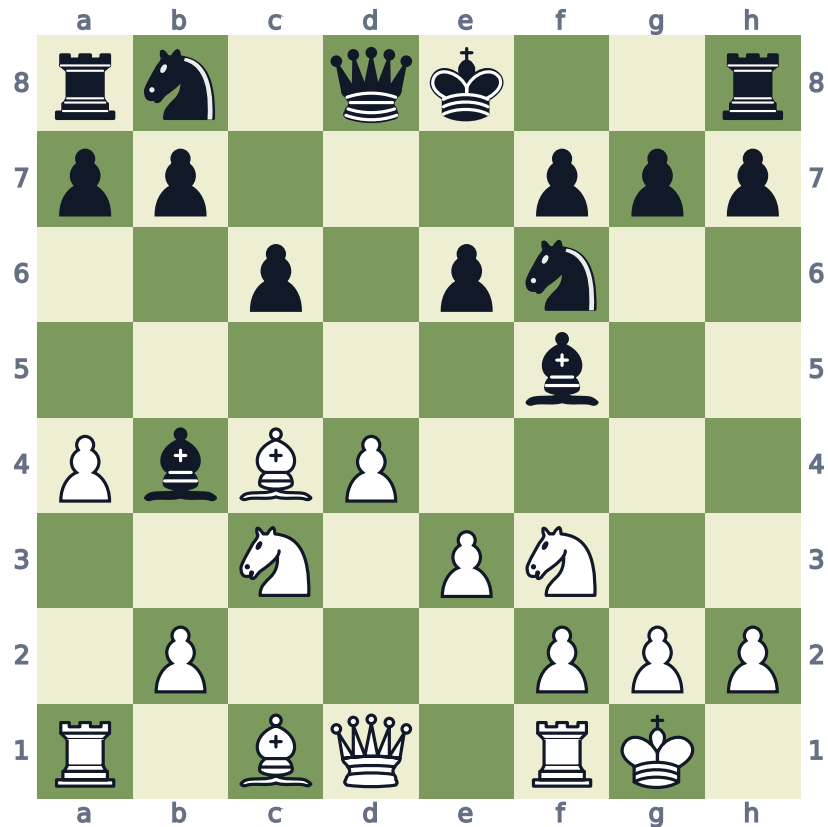
Approximate material: White 39, Black 39, difference +0. King placement: White not castled, Black castled. Pawn islands: White 1, Black 1. White plan: Develop pressure, choose between cxd5 and a maintained tension, and use active piece placement. Black plan: Complete development, prepare ...c5 or ...e5, and solve the c8-bishop. Thematic break: ...c5 is the standard freeing break; ...e5 is possible with preparation. Engine line: 1. dxc4 Bxc4 2. a6 O-O 3. b5 Bxf6 4. Nxf6 Bd3 Evaluation: -0.27 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.27 from the side-to-move perspective.

SOLUTION 30 OF 30

Slav Defense



VERIFIED LINE

1. O-O Nh4 2. a5 Qe2

WHY IT WORKS

Approximate material: White 38, Black 38, difference +0. King placement: White castled, Black not castled. Pawn islands: White 2, Black 2. White plan: Develop, recover c4 efficiently, and use e4 when the center permits it. Black plan: Develop the bishop before ...e6, decide whether to hold c4 briefly, and challenge the center. Thematic break: Black's ...c5 or ...e5 is the long-term freeing goal. Engine line: 1. O-O Nh4 2. a5 Qe2 Evaluation: -0.34 from the side-to-move perspective.

SCORING

1 point for each factor plus 2 for a coherent plan = 10 points Engine assessment: -0.34 from the side-to-move perspective.

REVIEW

Final mixed review

1

Select five missed positions and solve them in random order without motif names.

2

Explain why the best defense fails in each of those positions.

3

Reverse the board and describe whether the same geometry is still easy to recognize.

4

Find one example of the theme in your own game or a Fritz training game.

5

Retest under a shorter clock only after calculation is accurate without time pressure.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Repeat missed positions tomorrow, then after 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. Remove a position only after two correct solutions with a complete explanation.